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Model-Agnostic Interpretation of Machine Learning via Average Marginal Effects

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Abstract

We propose a framework for interpreting any supervised machine learning model through average marginal effects, the standard inferential tool in the econometrics of nonlinear models. The estimand is the window average marginal effect, the average centered finite difference of the regression function at a fixed, interpretable step. It is well defined for nowhere-differentiable learners and recovers the classical average derivative as the window shrinks. Because the functional is linear in the regression function, it admits an exact Riesz representation obtained by a change of variables, with no boundary terms or density derivatives, and the resulting orthogonal score has estimation bias exactly equal to a product of two squared-error norms. A cross-fitted debiased estimator is therefore root-n consistent and asymptotically normal whenever the learner and a Riesz-regression estimate of the representer converge faster than the fourth root of the sample size; it attains the semiparametric efficiency bound and returns a coefficient table analogous to parametric regression output without resampling. The score is also doubly robust. A pairing identity characterizes what the marginal effect of a tree-based model measures, and gradient consistency results for neural networks, boosted trees and Mondrian forests delineate when uncorrected plug-in effects are already consistent.

Key words: average marginal effects, cross-fitting, model-agnostic interpretability, Neyman orthogonality, Riesz representation, semiparametric efficiency

Introduction

The rise of flexible machine learning methods has created a persistent tension in empirical research. Models such as random forests (Breiman, 2001b), gradient boosted trees (Chen and Guestrin, 2016), and deep neural networks (Hastie et al., 2009) routinely achieve predictive accuracy that parametric models cannot match. Yet the standard tools of statistical inference — coefficient estimates, standard errors, hypothesis tests — apply naturally only to parametric models whose functional form is specified in advance. Breiman (2001a) framed this as a conflict between two cultures of statistical modeling: one oriented toward interpretable data-generating models, the other toward accurate algorithmic prediction. The conventional resolution has been to treat accuracy and interpretability as opposing ends of a spectrum, accepting reduced interpretability as the price of improved prediction. This paper argues that the tradeoff is not fundamental. It is an artifact of requiring parametric assumptions to make interpretation rigorous, and it disappears once that requirement is dropped.

The machine learning literature has produced a rich set of post-hoc interpretability methods that attempt to explain black-box model predictions without parametric assumptions. Partial dependence plots (Friedman, 2001) visualize the marginal relationship between a feature and the predicted outcome by averaging over the empirical distribution of other features. LIME (Ribeiro et al., 2016) fits a local linear approximation to the prediction function in the neighborhood of individual observations. SHAP (Lundberg and Lee, 2017) assigns each feature a contribution to each prediction based on Shapley values from cooperative game theory, providing a unified framework that nests several earlier methods. These tools are widely used in practice and are surveyed comprehensively in Molnar (2025) and Doshi-Velez and Kim (2017). However, they share a fundamental limitation: they produce point estimates with no associated sampling distributions. A SHAP value, a PDP slope, and a LIME coefficient are descriptive quantities — there is no standard error, no confidence interval, and no basis for a hypothesis test. A researcher cannot determine whether a SHAP value is statistically distinguishable from zero, or whether two features have significantly different effects, or whether the effect of a variable differs across model specifications. For applied researchers who need to draw defensible conclusions from their models, this is a serious constraint.

Two prior contributions are closest in spirit to the present paper. Scholbeck et al. (2024) propose forward marginal effects for nonlinear prediction functions as a model-agnostic interpretability method, establishing a general framework for computing feature effects for any supervised learner. Their framework is descriptive rather than inferential: it

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characterizes how feature effects vary across the covariate space but does not provide standard errors, confidence intervals, or hypothesis tests, and it explicitly argues against summarizing feature effects in a single metric such as the average marginal effect. The present paper takes the opposite position: we argue that the average marginal effect is precisely the right summary quantity, that it has a rigorous population-level interpretation inherited from the econometric literature, and that valid, semiparametrically efficient inference is achievable via a debiased, cross-fitted estimator with an explicit influence function. Löwe et al. (2024) provide the `fmeffects` R package implementing this descriptive framework, demonstrating the practical demand for marginal-effect-style interpretation of machine learning models, but without the theoretical justification — no population estimand, no efficiency theory, no characterization of when the marginal effects are well-defined — that the present paper provides through the Riesz representation of the effect functional and semiparametric efficiency theory.

The econometric literature has solved exactly this inferential problem for parametric models through average marginal effects (Greene, 2012; Wooldridge, 2010). For a generalized linear model with inverse link function μ and linear predictor $\eta = \mathbf{x}^\top \boldsymbol{\beta}$, the average marginal effect of variable j is $\text{AME}_j = \beta_j \cdot \mathbb{E}[\mu'(\eta)]$ — the regression coefficient scaled by the average derivative of the inverse link, averaged over the empirical distribution of the linear predictor. For the identity link this reduces to the OLS coefficient. For the logistic link it averages the logistic density over the sample. The result is a quantity measured in the natural units of the outcome, interpretable as the average change in the predicted outcome associated with a one-unit change in x_j, with standard errors obtained by the delta method or bootstrap. This is the output of `margins` in R and Stata (Leeper, 2021), and it is the standard form in which marginal effects are reported in applied economics, political science, sociology, and public health. The limitation is that it has been restricted to parametric models: to compute $\partial f / \partial x_j$ analytically, one must know the functional form of f.

A separate literature, largely disjoint from both the interpretability and the applied marginal effects traditions, has studied the population version of this quantity directly. The average derivative $\mathbb{E}[\partial_j f(X)]$ was introduced as an estimand in its own right by Härdle and Stoker (1989) and Powell et al. (1989), its semiparametric efficiency bounds were derived by Newey and Stoker (1993), and the modern debiased machine learning program (Chernozhukov et al., 2018, 2022) shows how to estimate linear functionals of a regression function at the parametric rate using flexible learners as nuisance estimators. The present paper is deliberately positioned at the junction of these literatures, and its delta relative to each is stated in one sentence: the debiasing literature tells one how to estimate $\mathbb{E}[\partial_j f(X)]$ efficiently when the derivative exists and the learner is treated as a black-box nuisance; this paper establishes what the estimand *is* when the learner is not differentiable — the window effect, with an exact finite-difference Riesz representation requiring no boundary conditions and no density derivatives — and shows that a single orthogonal score then covers smooth and piecewise constant learners, continuous and discrete regressors, within one construction. Conversely, relative to the interpretability literature, the contribution is to replace descriptive scores with an estimand–estimator–efficiency-bound triple of the classical kind.

This paper removes that restriction. We propose a framework for computing average marginal effects for any supervised machine learning model, requiring only that the prediction function $\hat{f}$ can be evaluated at a point. The estimand is the *window average marginal effect*: the expectation of a centered finite difference of the regression function at a fixed step h scaled to the spread of each feature, trimmed away from the boundary of the support. Treating the finite difference as the estimand rather than as a numerical approximation to a derivative is what makes genuine model-agnosticism possible — the window effect is well defined for tree-based models, for which classical derivatives do not exist anywhere — while the classical average derivative is recovered as the $h \to 0$ limit whenever the regression function has one weak derivative, so nothing is given up relative to the econometric tradition. Estimation combines the plug-in average of finite differences with an orthogonal correction term built from an explicit Riesz representer, computed by cross-fitting; standard errors come from the estimated influence function in a single pass, with no resampling required, and a multiplier bootstrap is available at no additional model fits when a resampling distribution is wanted. The result is a coefficient table — estimate, standard error, and significance level — directly analogous to the output of a parametric regression but with no restrictions on the functional form of $\hat{f}$. The framework nests the classical GLM result as a special case: when $\hat{f}$ is a logistic regression, the estimator recovers the classical AME automatically. When $\hat{f}$ is XGBoost or a random forest or a neural network, the same formula applies and produces output on the same scale and with the same interpretation, and for binary regressors the construction specializes to augmented inverse probability weighting with the regressor in the role of the treatment.

The theoretical contribution proceeds in three parts, which answer in turn the questions of inference, optimality, and interpretation. First, because the window functional is linear in the regression function, a change of variables yields an exact Riesz representation with an explicitly computable representer, bounded whenever the covariate density is — no integration by parts, no boundary terms, and no derivatives of the covariate density — and the bias of the resulting orthogonal moment is exactly a product of two L^2 estimation errors. A cross-fitted estimator built on this score is root-n consistent and asymptotically normal whenever the learner and a Riesz-regression estimate of the representer each converge faster than $n^{-1/4}$ in L^2 — a condition of the kind modern learning theory actually verifies, in place of the parametric-rate function-space convergence that a delta-method treatment would demand and that no growing-complexity learner satisfies. Second, the score is the efficient influence function: the estimator attains the semiparametric efficiency bound for the window effect, whose variance decomposes into the heterogeneity of the effect and a noise term amplified by the representer, making the cost of narrow windows explicit. The score is moreover doubly robust: with a known or parametrically estimated representer — simulation designs, designed experiments, randomized treatments — inference remains valid with no consistency requirement on the learner at all, covering the fixed-complexity defaults under which off-the-shelf learners converge to pseudo-true limits rather than to the truth. Third, a pairing identity characterizes what the marginal effect of a non-differentiable model measures: for any estimator of bounded variation — every tree-based model — the window effect equals the jump measure of the fitted surface integrated against a locally averaged covariate density, an exact geometric description of the population quantity that a forest's coefficient tracks. Supporting this

interpretation theory, gradient consistency is established for neural networks (Hornik et al., 1990) in the Sobolev space $W^{1,p}$, via the Rellich–Kondrachov compact embedding theorem (Evans, 2010), and for gradient boosted models with tree base learners and Mondrian forests (Lakshminarayanan et al., 2014; Mourtada et al., 2017) in the space of functions of bounded variation (Ambrosio et al., 2000), via the BV compactness theorem. For Breiman forests (Breiman, 2001b; Scornet et al., 2015), gradient consistency is conjectured rather than proved, with the obstruction identified precisely; because the inference theory requires gradient consistency for no class, this leaves two Breiman questions of unequal difficulty — valid inference needs only an L^2 rate from the forest, while the gradient question, which bears on interpretation rather than on coverage, remains a function-space problem and remains open.

We validate the framework empirically on three datasets spanning binary classification in social science, binary classification in finance, and continuous regression: the UCI Adult Income dataset (Kohavi, 1996; Dua and Graff, 2019), the UCI Credit Card Default dataset (Yeh, 2009; Dua and Graff, 2019), and the Ames Housing dataset (De Cock, 2011). Across all three applications we compare AMEs from logistic regression, random forests (Breiman, 2001b), XGBoost (Chen and Guestrin, 2016), and neural networks against SHAP values (Lundberg and Lee, 2017) and partial dependence plot slopes (Friedman, 2001). The debiased AMEs agree closely across the four model classes, which is what one expects once every learner is used to estimate the same window effect rather than to report its own slope, while SHAP values answer a different question — additive attribution relative to a baseline rather than a rate of change — and are correspondingly on a different scale and sometimes of opposite sign — a divergence that is most visible in the regression setting where units are dollars and the magnitudes are large enough to make the discrepancy concrete. PDP slopes, being themselves plug-in averages over a single full-sample fit, track the debiased AME where the plug-in is nearly unbiased and fall short of it, usually toward zero, wherever regularization flattens the fitted surface — the regularization bias made directly visible. Because AMEs come with standard errors and SHAP values and PDP slopes do not, the AME framework supports conclusions that the alternatives cannot. The credit default application is the sharpest case, and it is worth stating at the outset. Under the plug-in the four learners put the effect of the payment ratio at -0.431 and -0.440 for the two tree ensembles, -0.045 for logistic regression, and 0.0009 — effectively nothing — for the neural network: a set of estimates that cannot all be describing the same world, and among which a reader had no principled way to adjudicate. Under the correction those same four become -0.489, -0.584, -0.265 and -0.194 respectively, every one of them negative and substantial. The disagreement was not four models detecting different structure. It was the regularization bias $\mathbb{E}[\alpha_h(\hat{f} - f)]$, which differs across learners because their regularization differs, and which the orthogonal score removes.

An additional finding concerns Breiman random forests, which are the learner the framework is most often asked to carry and the one for which the interpretation theory is least complete. Under the uncorrected plug-in they behave worst of the four classes: the simulation study shows a bias that does not vanish with the sample size but grows with it, from -0.097 at $n = 250$ to -0.091 at $n = 5{,}000$ in the linear regression design, so that intervals shrink at the usual rate around a center that is not moving and coverage collapses to 0.130. The orthogonal correction removes that term. Estimating the same quantity on the same draws with the debiased estimator leaves a bias in the fourth decimal at every sample size and returns coverage to a mean of 0.948 against the nominal 0.95, within the band 0.922 to 0.968 across all one hundred and twenty forest cells of the design — every data generating process, sample size, feature and outcome type. This is more than a bias correction, and the reason matters for which learners the framework can be used with. A depth-constrained forest whose plug-in error grows with n is not converging to f, and Proposition 2 says that with the representer known this costs nothing: the estimator is root-n normal about $\theta_h(f)$ even when $\hat{f}$ converges to some other function entirely. The simulation is that proposition observed rather than merely a demonstration that the correction is well calibrated. Because the inference theory consumes gradient consistency for no learner class, the Breiman forest is the natural choice for applied work rather than a concession, and what remains open for that class is the separate interpretive question of whether its window effect converges to a classical derivative as $h \to 0$.

The remainder of the paper is organized as follows. Section 2 defines the estimand, presents the estimator, and establishes its relationship to classical average marginal effects for the GLM family. Section 3 develops the asymptotic theory: the window estimand and its Riesz representation, the orthogonal score with cross-fitting, root-n asymptotic normality and semiparametric efficiency, the pairing identity for estimators of bounded variation, gradient consistency for three learner classes, and the nuisance rates that the conditions require. Section 4 presents the credit default application, the other two being deferred to the supplement. Section 5 presents simulation evidence on finite-sample performance, summarized in the main text and reported in full in the supplement. Section 6 concludes. The supplement also contains proofs of every result stated in Section 3.

Method

We propose a framework for interpreting any supervised machine learning model through the lens of average marginal effects. The framework is agnostic to the choice of learner — the same estimation procedure applies whether $\hat{f}$ is a neural network, a gradient boosted model, a random forest, or any other supervised learner. Crucially, the framework produces standard errors from the influence function of a Neyman-orthogonal score, evaluated by cross-fitting, enabling hypothesis tests and confidence intervals that existing model-agnostic interpretability methods do not support. A refitting bootstrap is retained, but as a diagnostic rather than as the basis for inference: Section 3.4 shows that it is blind to the learner's regularization bias, which is precisely the term the orthogonal correction removes. SHAP values and permutation-based feature importance measures provide point estimates of variable importance but no basis for inference. The average marginal effect estimator proposed here yields a coefficient table — estimate, standard error, and significance — directly analogous to the output of a parametric regression, with no restrictions on the functional form of $\hat{f}$.

Estimand

Let $\mathbf{x}_i = (x_{i1}, \ldots, x_{ip})^\top \in \mathbb{R}^p$ denote the feature vector for observation i, and let $y_i \in \mathbb{R}$ denote the outcome. We observe n independent draws $\{(\mathbf{x}_i, y_i)\}_{i=1}^n$ from some population distribution P. Let $f : \mathbb{R}^p \to \mathbb{R}$ denote the

conditional expectation function $f(\mathbf{x}) = E[Y \mid \mathbf{x}]$. For binary outcomes, $f(\mathbf{x}) = P(Y = 1 \mid \mathbf{x})$ is the conditional probability of the positive class; for continuous outcomes, $f(\mathbf{x}) = E[Y \mid \mathbf{x}]$ directly. In both cases f is the same object — the conditional expectation of Y given $\mathbf{x}$ — and the method requires no modification across outcome types.

The marginal effect of variable j at observation i is the partial derivative of f evaluated at $\mathbf{x}_i$:

$$m_{ij} = \frac{\partial f}{\partial x_j}\bigg|_{\mathbf{x}_i} \tag{2.1}$$

The population average marginal effect of variable j is:

$$\mathrm{AME}_j = \mathbb{E}\left[\frac{\partial f}{\partial x_j}(\mathbf{x})\right] \tag{2.2}$$

where the expectation is taken over the marginal distribution of $\mathbf{x}$ under P. This is the classical target. The operational estimand of the paper is its finite-window counterpart, the *window average marginal effect* $\theta_{j,h} = \mathbb{E}[w(\mathbf{x})\,\{f(\mathbf{x} + he_j) - f(\mathbf{x} - he_j)\}/2h]$, where $h > 0$ is a fixed step scaled to the spread of x_j and w is a trimming weight that excludes points within h of the boundary of the support. The window effect is well defined for any bounded prediction function — no derivative need exist anywhere, which is what a genuinely model-agnostic estimand requires — and it converges to AME_j as $h \to 0$ whenever f has one weak derivative. Both facts, and the conditions under which the estimators below converge, are established in Section 3.

Estimation

Given an estimator $\hat{f}$ of f, the sample analog is:

$$\widehat{\mathrm{AME}}_j = \frac{1}{n}\sum_{i=1}^{n} \frac{\partial \hat{f}}{\partial x_j}\bigg|_{\mathbf{x}_i} \tag{2.3}$$

For most supervised learners the partial derivative $\partial\hat{f}/\partial x_j$ is not available in closed form, and for tree-based models it does not exist everywhere in the classical sense. We therefore estimate it via a centered finite difference:

$$\frac{\partial \hat{f}}{\partial x_j}\bigg|_{\mathbf{x}_i} \approx \frac{\hat{f}\left(\mathbf{x}_i^{(j,\, x_{ij}+h_j)}\right) - \hat{f}\left(\mathbf{x}_i^{(j,\, x_{ij}-h_j)}\right)}{2h_j} \tag{2.4}$$

where $\mathbf{x}_i^{(j,v)}$ denotes the vector $\mathbf{x}_i$ with the j-th component replaced by v. We write $\Delta_{j,h}g(\mathbf{x})$ for the right-hand side of (2.4) applied to a generic function g, so that the sample analog above is $n^{-1}\sum_i \Delta_{j,h}\hat{f}(\mathbf{x}_i)$; the same notation is used throughout Section 3. The centered finite difference is preferred over a one-sided difference because its approximation error relative to the pointwise derivative is $O(h_j^2)$ rather than $O(h_j)$, which becomes material when h_j is not negligibly small. Relative to the window estimand $\theta_{j,h}$ the centered difference involves no approximation at all: it is the defining operation of the estimand, computed exactly, and h_j is a reported feature of the target — the perturbation scale at which effects are measured — rather than a numerical tolerance.

The step size h_j is chosen adaptively as:

$$h_j = \max\left(10^{-4},\ 0.05 \cdot \hat{\sigma}_j\right) \tag{2.5}$$

where $\hat{\sigma}_j$ is the sample standard deviation of the j-th feature. Scaling h_j to the spread of x_j ensures the finite difference is neither so small as to introduce numerical instability nor so large as to obscure local behavior. The floor of 10^{-4} guards against degenerate cases where $\hat{\sigma}_j \approx 0$. Observations within h_j of the boundary of the observed support receive trimming weight zero, so that $\hat{f}$ is never evaluated at points where the regression function is unidentified; the trimmed shell carries probability mass of order h_j, and with the default step this exclusion is small. Untrimmed evaluation — the default in earlier implementations — silently extrapolates the fitted model outside the support, and the trimming weight should be understood as the repair of that extrapolation rather than as a restriction of the method.

For binary or categorical variables the partial derivative does not exist and the finite difference is replaced by a contrast. The marginal effect for observation i is:

$$m_{ij} = \hat{f}\left(\mathbf{x}_i^{(j,1)}\right) - \hat{f}\left(\mathbf{x}_i^{(j,0)}\right) \tag{2.6}$$

which measures the change in predicted outcome when x_j is switched from 0 to 1 holding all other variables at their observed values. The sample average marginal effect is then $\widehat{\mathrm{AME}}_j = n^{-1}\sum_{i=1}^{n} m_{ij}$, with interpretation identical to the continuous case: a change in x_j from 0 to 1 is associated with a $\widehat{\mathrm{AME}}_j$ change in the predicted outcome, on average across the sample.

For binary classification models, $\hat{f}$ must return the estimated conditional probability $\hat{P}(Y = 1 \mid \mathbf{x})$ rather than the predicted class label. Class labels are discrete and their finite differences are identically zero; the method requires a continuous output. This is the predicted probability of the positive class, available as `predict_proba(X)[:,1]` in scikit-learn and equivalent interfaces in other frameworks. The AME is then interpreted as the change in predicted probability associated with a one-unit change in x_j, on average across the sample.

Relationship to Classical Average Marginal Effects

Average marginal effects are a standard tool in the econometrics of nonlinear models (Greene, 2012; Wooldridge, 2010). For parametric models the estimator $\widehat{\mathrm{AME}}_j$ defined above reduces exactly to the classical result. Consider a generalized linear model with inverse link function μ and linear predictor $\eta_i = \mathbf{x}_i^\top\boldsymbol{\beta}$, so that $f(\mathbf{x}_i) = \mu(\eta_i)$. The marginal effect of variable j at observation i is:

$$\frac{\partial f}{\partial x_j}\bigg|_{\mathbf{x}_i} = \beta_j \cdot \mu'(\eta_i) \tag{2.7}$$

and the population average marginal effect is $\mathrm{AME}_j = \beta_j \cdot E[\mu'(\eta)]$. For the identity link $\mu'(\eta) = 1$ and $\mathrm{AME}_j = \beta_j$ — the marginal effect is constant across observations and equals the OLS coefficient. For the logistic link $\mu'(\eta) = \Lambda(\eta)(1-\Lambda(\eta))$ and the AME averages the logistic density over the sample (Greene, 2012). For the probit link $\mu'(\eta) = \phi(\eta)$, the standard normal density evaluated at the linear predictor (Wooldridge, 2010).

In each case $\widehat{\mathrm{AME}}_j$ recovers the classical result automatically — the finite difference applied to the model output numerically approximates $\beta_j \cdot \mu'(\eta_i)$ without requiring knowledge of the link function. The framework therefore nests the entire GLM family as a special case and reduces to familiar output when the model is parametric. This backward compatibility is what the `marginaleffects` package in R and Python implements (Arel-Bundock et al., 2024); the present framework extends that implementation with formal asymptotic guarantees for machine learning models.

Inference

Inference is based on a debiased, cross-fitted estimator whose formal analysis is the subject of Section 3; here we describe the procedure. Partition the sample into K folds ($K = 5$ by default). For each fold k, using only the observations outside the fold: (1) fit the learner $\hat{f}^{(-k)}$ exactly as it would be fit in any application, tuning included if the learner is tuned, using only that fold's training portion; (2) fit an estimate $\hat{\alpha}^{(-k)}$ of the Riesz representer of the window effect — an explicit weight function characterized in Section 3 — by minimizing an empirical quadratic loss that requires only evaluating candidate functions at the shifted points $\mathbf{x}_i \pm h_j e_j$, with no density estimation of any kind. The estimate of $\theta_{j,h}$ averages, over the held-out observations of every fold, the finite difference of the out-of-fold learner plus a correction term:

$$\hat{\theta}_{j,h} = \frac{1}{n} \sum_{k=1}^{K} \sum_{i \in I_k} \left[w(\mathbf{x}_i)\, \Delta_{j,h} \hat{f}^{(-k)}(\mathbf{x}_i) + \hat{\alpha}^{(-k)}(\mathbf{x}_i)\, \left(y_i - \hat{f}^{(-k)}(\mathbf{x}_i)\right) \right] \tag{2.8}$$

The first term is the plug-in average of Section 2.2 computed on held-out data; the second term removes, at first order, the bias that regularization of the learner transmits to the plug-in average — each held-out residual, weighted by the representer, testifies to how the learner is locally mis-calibrated where that mis-calibration matters for the marginal effect. For binary and categorical variables the same formula applies with the contrast in place of the finite difference and inverse propensity weights in the role of the representer.

Standard errors require no resampling: the summands above, centered at $\hat{\theta}_{j,h}$, are estimates of the influence function values, and the standard error is the sample standard deviation of those values divided by $\sqrt{n}$. The coefficient table — estimate, standard error, t-statistic, and p-value for each feature — is therefore produced by K model fits in total, in place of the hundreds of refits that a bootstrap requires; Section 3 establishes that the resulting confidence intervals are asymptotically valid and that the estimator attains the semiparametric efficiency bound. When a full resampling distribution is wanted — for simultaneous confidence bands across features, for example — a multiplier bootstrap that perturbs the estimated influence function values with i.i.d. mean-zero weights is available at no additional model fits.

The package additionally retains a nonparametric model-refitting bootstrap (Efron, 1979; Efron and Tibshirani, 1993) as a *diagnostic* for how far the fitted function moves when the sample is perturbed — variability that the asymptotic theory conditions away. The learner's settings are held fixed across replicates; if the learner is tuned, the tuning is part of what each replicate refits. For $b = 1, \ldots, B$: draw $\mathcal{D}^{(b)}$ by resampling $(\mathbf{x}_i, y_i)$ pairs jointly with replacement; refit $\hat{f}^{(b)}$ on $\mathcal{D}^{(b)}$ from a fresh initialization at the same settings; and recompute the plug-in average marginal effect. The dispersion of the replicates measures how sensitive the reported effects are to the joint variability of resampling and refitting, and large dispersion is a useful warning that the fitted model is unstable. It is not, however, a substitute for the influence function standard errors above, for reasons Section 3 makes precise: the refitting bootstrap recenters at the fitted model and is therefore blind to the regularization bias that the correction term removes — a blindness whose consequences for coverage are documented for random forests in Section 5 — and, because each replicate is evaluated at the original sample, it omits the component of sampling variance that comes from averaging a heterogeneous effect over a finite sample of covariate values.

Asymptotic Theory

Overview

The asymptotic theory must deliver three things. First, a population estimand that is well defined for any supervised learner, including learners such as trees and forests whose prediction functions are not differentiable anywhere. Second, valid root-n inference on that estimand under conditions that flexible machine learning estimators can actually satisfy — in particular, without requiring the learner itself to converge at the parametric rate, a condition that fails whenever the complexity of the function class grows with the sample size. Third, an account of what the gradient of a fitted model measures: when the average marginal effect of a fitted forest is computed, what population quantity is that number tracking? This section delivers the three in turn.

The organizing observation is structural: the average marginal effect is a *linear* functional of the regression function. Linearity has three consequences that together carry the entire theory. First, the functional admits an exact Riesz representation — there is an explicit, bounded weight function α_h such that averaging the finite difference of any function against the covariate distribution equals averaging the function itself against α_h (Lemma 1). The representation is obtained by a change of variables rather than integration by parts, so no boundary terms arise and no derivative of the covariate density is ever needed. Second, the estimation bias of a debiased moment built from this representation is *exactly* a product of two estimation errors (Lemma 2) — not a product plus a linearization remainder, as for nonlinear functionals, but an identity. Root-n inference therefore requires only that the product of the L^2 errors of two nuisance estimates be $o_p(n^{-1/2})$ — for instance, both converging faster than $n^{-1/4}$ — rather than root-n convergence of the learner in any norm (Theorem 1). Third, the resulting estimator attains the semiparametric efficiency bound for the estimand (Theorem 2): among all regular estimators, none has smaller asymptotic variance.

The estimand the theory analyzes is exactly the quantity the estimator of Section 2 computes: the average of a centered finite difference at a fixed step h, which we call the *window average marginal effect*. Treating h as part of the estimand rather than as a numerical approximation to a derivative has two payoffs. The window effect is well defined for any bounded prediction function — no differentiability anywhere — which is what makes a genuinely model-agnostic theory possible. And the classical average derivative is recovered as the $h \to 0$ limit whenever the true regression function has one weak derivative (Proposition 1), so nothing classical is given up. A trimming weight confines the evaluation points to the interior of the support; the binary and categorical contrasts of Section 2 fit the same template, with the change of variables running over a two-point support and the representer reducing to inverse-probability weights (Remark 2).

The interpretation question is answered by a pairing identity (Theorem 3). For any estimator of bounded variation — which includes every tree-based model — the window average marginal effect of the *fitted* model equals the integral of a locally averaged covariate density against the distributional gradient of the fitted model: for a tree, a sum of leaf boundary

jumps weighted by the boundary's share of smoothed covariate mass. This makes precise, apparently for the first time, which population quantity the marginal effect of a piecewise constant learner measures. The Sobolev and BV lemmas of Section 3.5 then characterize the regime in which the learner's own gradient converges to the population gradient — the strongest interpretability guarantee available, and the condition under which the uncorrected plug-in estimator of Section 2 is already consistent. Those results describe when the correction term is a refinement; the inference theory of Theorem 1 does not depend on them.

The relationship between the debiased estimator and the plug-in-plus-bootstrap procedure of Section 2 is worth stating plainly. The plug-in average is the first component of the orthogonal score; the correction term $\alpha_h(x_i)\,(y_i - \hat{f}(x_i))$ removes, at first order, the bias transmitted to the average marginal effect by regularization of the learner. The simulation evidence in Section 5 displays exactly this mechanism: random forest confidence intervals built from the uncorrected plug-in collapse to near-zero coverage at large n because the intervals concentrate around a regularization-biased center — the bias term the correction is constructed to remove. The model-refitting bootstrap of Section 2 remains a useful diagnostic for specification uncertainty, but the inferential guarantees of this section attach to the debiased estimator and its influence function, not to the uncorrected plug-in.

Notation and Preliminaries

Let $\Omega \subset \mathbb{R}^d$ be a bounded Lipschitz domain and let $f : \Omega \to \mathbb{R}$ be the true underlying function relating covariates to outcomes. Let $\hat{f}_n : \Omega \to \mathbb{R}$ denote an estimator of f constructed from n observations $\{(x_i, y_i)\}_{i=1}^n$. We assume throughout that Ω is bounded and Lipschitz, which ensures the compactness and embedding results we rely on are available. These are mild regularity conditions satisfied by any compact covariate space with reasonable boundary behavior.

Throughout, $(\mathbf{x}_i, y_i)_{i=1}^n$ are independent draws from P, the joint distribution of (X, Y); with mild abuse of notation P also denotes the marginal distribution of the covariates, with $\|g\|_{P,2}^2 = \mathbb{E}[g(X)^2]$ the corresponding L^2 norm. We fix a coordinate $j \in \{1, \ldots, d\}$ for the remainder of the section and suppress it from the notation where no confusion arises. Recalling the centered difference operator of Section 2.2, now written for a general step size $h > 0$:

$$\Delta_{j,h} g(x) = \frac{g(x + he_j) - g(x - he_j)}{2h} \tag{3.1}$$

where e_j is the j-th coordinate vector, and let $\Omega_{j,h} = \{x \in \Omega : x + he_j \in \Omega \text{ and } x - he_j \in \Omega\}$ denote the set of points whose shifted evaluations remain in the domain. A *trimming weight* is a measurable function $w : \Omega \to [0, 1]$ with $\operatorname{supp}(w) \subseteq \Omega_{j,h}$; it confines the finite difference to points where both shifted arguments lie inside the support, so that the prediction function is never evaluated where the regression function is unidentified. The following conditions are maintained throughout the section.

Assumption 1 The data are i.i.d. draws from P with $\mathbb{E}[Y^2] < \infty$ and $\operatorname{Var}(Y \mid X = x) \le \bar{\sigma}^2 < \infty$ for P-almost every x. The covariate distribution admits a density p on Ω with $0 < p_{\min} \le p(x) \le p_{\max} < \infty$ for all $x \in \Omega$.

The density bounds are the same condition previously used to define the average marginal effect functional and are standard in the average derivative literature (Powell et al., 1989; Newey and Stoker, 1993). They enter the theory only through the ratio $p_{\max}/p_{\min}$, which bounds the Riesz representer above.

The bounds are genuinely restrictive, and one design of interest violates them. Independent Gaussian covariates have a density that is not bounded below on $\mathbb{R}^d$, and the representer of Lemma 1 is then unbounded. That case is covered by an alternative to the density bounds, under which every result of this section continues to hold with the sup-norm conditions replaced by moment conditions.

Assumption 2 (Unbounded support) In place of the density bounds of Assumption 1: (a) $p(x) > 0$ for every $x \in \Omega$; (b) there exists $r > 1$ with

$$\mathbb{E}\left[\left(\frac{p(X - he_j)}{p(X)}\right)^r\right] < \infty \quad \text{and} \quad \mathbb{E}\left[\left(\frac{p(X + he_j)}{p(X)}\right)^r\right] < \infty \tag{3.2}$$

and (c) $\alpha_h \in L^q(P)$ for some $q > 2$. The moment conditions on Y in Assumption 1 are retained unchanged.

Condition (b) is precisely what the density bounds were doing in the proofs. Every appeal to $p_{\min}$ below reduces to controlling a shifted second moment, $\mathbb{E}[g(X \pm he_j)^2] = \mathbb{E}[g(X)^2\, p(X \mp he_j)/p(X)]$, which a uniform density bound handles by brute force and which (3.2) handles by Hölder, at the cost of a slightly higher integrability requirement on g. Condition (c) replaces the sup-norm bound that Lemma 1 supplies in the bounded case; it is an assumption here rather than a conclusion, because with an unbounded density the explicit formula for α_h need not be bounded even though it remains square integrable.

Section 5 exhibits both assumption sets. Its Gaussian designs satisfy Assumption 2 while failing Assumption 1; a bounded-support arm, with the covariates drawn uniformly on a box, satisfies Assumption 1 literally and carries a representer bounded by $1/(2h)$. Coverage agrees between them to within four thousandths, so nothing in what follows depends on which route is taken. For independent standard normal covariates the shift ratio is $p(u - he_j)/p(u) = \exp(hu_j - h^2/2)$, which has moments of every order, so (b) holds for every r; and the representer is $\alpha_h(u) = e^{-h^2/2} \sinh(hu_j)/h$, for which

$$\mathbb{E}\left[\alpha_h(X)^2\right] = \frac{e^{-h^2}}{h^2}\,\mathbb{E}\left[\sinh^2(hX_j)\right] = \frac{e^{-h^2}\left(e^{2h^2} - 1\right)}{2h^2} < \infty \tag{3.3}$$

with all higher moments finite as well, so (c) holds for every q. The representer is unbounded — sinh grows exponentially — which is exactly why the sup-norm route is unavailable and the moment route is needed.

We work with two function spaces depending on the estimator class. The choice of function space is not arbitrary—each space is the natural habitat of the estimator class in question, in the sense that estimators of that class belong to the space with probability one under mild conditions.

The **Sobolev space** $W^{k,p}(\Omega)$ for $k \ge 1$ and $p \ge 1$ consists of functions whose weak derivatives up to order k are in $L^p(\Omega)$, with norm:

$$\|g\|_{W^{k,p}} = \sum_{|\alpha| \le k} \|\partial^\alpha g\|_{L^p} \tag{3.4}$$

The gradient $\nabla g \in L^p(\Omega)^d$ is a vector valued L^p function for any $g \in W^{1,p}(\Omega)$. Sobolev spaces are the natural setting

for smooth estimators because they quantify not just how well the function is approximated in L^p but how well its derivatives are approximated simultaneously. This is exactly the property needed to justify gradient based interpretation—L^p consistency of $\hat{f}_n$ alone is insufficient because differentiation is an unbounded operator on L^p, and convergence of a function does not in general imply convergence of its derivatives without additional regularity (Evans, 2010, Chapter 5).

The **space of functions of bounded variation** $BV(\Omega)$ consists of functions $g \in L^1(\Omega)$ whose distributional gradient Dg is a vector valued Radon measure with finite total variation $|Dg|(\Omega) < \infty$. The BV norm is:

$$\|g\|_{BV} = \|g\|_{L^1} + |Dg|(\Omega) \tag{3.5}$$

The BV framework extends the notion of gradient to functions that are not differentiable in the classical or even weak sense—precisely the situation with tree based estimators, which have jump discontinuities at leaf boundaries. For piecewise constant functions the distributional gradient is a sum of surface measures concentrated on the boundaries between constant regions, capturing the intuition that the "derivative" of a step function is a spike at the jump location. This makes BV the natural space for random forests and boosting with tree base learners. The total variation $|Dg|(\Omega)$ measures the total size of all jumps, weighted by the boundary surface area—a quantity that is finite and well controlled for any piecewise constant function with finitely many pieces. The standard reference for the theory of BV functions is Ambrosio et al. (2000).

The relationship between the two spaces is important. If $f \in W^{1,p}(\Omega)$ for $p \geq 1$, then $f \in BV(\Omega)$ with $Df = \nabla f \cdot \mathcal{L}^d$—that is, the distributional gradient of f is absolutely continuous with respect to Lebesgue measure with density ∇f. This embedding $W^{1,p} \hookrightarrow BV$ means that assuming $f \in W^{1,p}(\Omega)$ is sufficient for both the Sobolev and BV results below. We make this assumption throughout.

Definition 1 (Well-Behaved Estimator, Sobolev Sense) We say that $\hat{f}_n$ is *well-behaved in the Sobolev sense* if:

$$\sup_n \left\|\hat{f}_n\right\|_{W^{2,p}} < \infty \quad \text{and} \quad \left\|\hat{f}_n - f\right\|_{L^p} \xrightarrow{p} 0 \tag{3.6}$$

Definition 2 (Well-Behaved Estimator, BV Sense) We say that $\hat{f}_n$ is *well-behaved in the BV sense* if:

$$\sup_n \mathbb{E}\left[|D\hat{f}_n|(\Omega)\right] < \infty \quad \text{and} \quad \left\|\hat{f}_n - f\right\|_{L^1} \xrightarrow{p} 0 \tag{3.7}$$

In both cases the well-behaved condition has the same structure: a uniform boundedness condition in a strong space combined with consistency in a weaker space. The uniform boundedness condition is the key regularity requirement—it says that the estimator sequence does not become increasingly irregular as n grows, even as it fits the data more closely. This condition is verifiable from properties of the estimator class and is established for each class in the theorems below. The consistency condition is the standard requirement that the estimator converges to the truth and is available from existing results in each case.

The Window Estimand and Its Riesz Representation

Definition 3 (Window Average Marginal Effect) Fix $h > 0$ and a trimming weight w with $\text{supp}(w) \subseteq \Omega_{j,h}$. The *window average marginal effect* of variable j at scale h is:

$$\theta_h(f) = \mathbb{E}\left[w(X)\,\Delta_{j,h} f(X)\right] \tag{3.8}$$

Up to the trimming weight, $\theta_h(f)$ is exactly the population counterpart of the quantity the estimator of Section 2 computes: the finite difference at step h is not a numerical approximation to a derivative that the theory then ignores, but the defining operation of the estimand itself. The step size is a fixed feature of the estimand, chosen and reported by the analyst exactly as a bandwidth is, and the default $h_j = 0.05\,\hat{\sigma}_j$ of Section 2 corresponds to asking how the predicted outcome responds to displacements of a twentieth of a standard deviation — an economically interpretable perturbation scale. Two features deserve emphasis. First, $\theta_h(f)$ is well defined for any bounded measurable f: no differentiability is assumed anywhere, which is what permits a single estimand to cover neural networks and regression trees simultaneously. Second, the trimming weight repairs a defect of the untrimmed implementation, which evaluates $\hat{f}$ at points $x_i \pm he_j$ that may fall outside the support of the covariates, where the regression function is not identified; w excises a boundary shell of probability mass $O(h)$ and confines every evaluation to the region where f means something.

Remark 1 (Data-dependent step sizes) *Definition 3 fixes h, and every result below is a statement about the estimand at that fixed value. The default of Section 2 sets $h_j = \max(10^{-4}, 0.05\,\hat{\sigma}_j)$, which is a function of the data. The two are reconciled by reading all results conditional on the realized $\hat{h}$: the reported quantity is the window effect at the step actually used, which is why h_j is reported alongside every estimate in Table 2 rather than being treated as a tuning parameter. Nothing in the argument requires h to be non-random — the representation of Lemma 1, the orthogonality of Lemma 2 and the expansion of Theorem 1 all hold pointwise in h — and the conditional reading is the natural one, because the estimand is genuinely indexed by the perturbation scale the analyst chose.*

It is worth being explicit about what the conditional reading buys, since the alternative is not free. If one insists instead that the target is θ_{h_0} at the deterministic limit $h_0 = 0.05\,\sigma_j$, then whenever $h \mapsto \theta_h(f)$ is differentiable at h_0 the delta method gives $\theta_{\hat{h}} - \theta_{h_0} = \theta'_{h_0}(\hat{h} - h_0) + o_p(n^{-1/2})$, and since $\hat{\sigma}_j$ is root-n consistent this is $O_p(n^{-1/2})$ — the same order as the sampling error itself. The substitution is therefore not *asymptotically negligible: it contributes a term to the limiting variance, and an unconditional treatment would have to add that term to V_h. We do not pursue this, because the conditional statement is the one that matches how the estimand is used and reported. An analyst who wants the unconditional reading can fix h from prior information or from a pilot sample, at which point the two coincide.*

The estimand admits an exact dual representation, which is the engine of everything that follows. Extend $q = wp$ by zero outside Ω.

Lemma 1 (Riesz Representation) *Let Assumption 1 hold and define:*

$$\alpha_h(u) = \frac{q(u - he_j) - q(u + he_j)}{2h\,p(u)}, \qquad u \in \Omega \tag{3.9}$$

Then for every $g \in L^1(P)$:

$$\mathbb{E}\left[w(X)\,\Delta_{j,h} g(X)\right] = \mathbb{E}\left[\alpha_h(X)\,g(X)\right] \tag{3.10}$$

Moreover $\mathbb{E}[\alpha_h(X)] = 0$*, and under the density bounds of Assumption 1,* $\|\alpha_h\|_\infty \le p_{\max}/(h\, p_{\min})$*. Under Assumption 2 the representer need not be bounded, and* (3.10) *holds for every* g *with* $\alpha_h g \in L^1(P)$*.*

The proof is a change of variables in each half of the finite difference and nothing more. This is worth dwelling on, because it is the point at which the present theory parts ways with the classical average derivative literature. For the derivative functional $\mathbb{E}[\partial_j f(X)]$, the analogous representation is obtained by integration by parts, the representer is the negative score $-\partial_j \log p$ of the covariate density, and a boundary term appears that must be killed by assuming the density vanishes on the boundary — an assumption incompatible with a density bounded away from zero on a compact support, and the reason Powell et al. (1989) pass to density-weighted variants. For the window functional the integration by parts is replaced by exact summation: no boundary term ever arises, because the trimming weight guarantees that every shifted evaluation point stays inside Ω. The representer involves the density only through ratios of its values at points $2h$ apart — no derivative of p, and hence no density derivative estimation, is ever required. The mean-zero property follows from applying (3.10) to $g \equiv 1$, and the uniform bound makes α_h a bounded weight function, in contrast to the unbounded score-based representers of the derivative functional. The cost of the exactness is the factor h^{-1} in the bound: smaller windows mean noisier representers, the familiar bias–variance logic of a bandwidth, here appearing in the variance of the efficient influence function rather than in a smoothing bias.

The classical estimand is recovered in the small-window limit.

Proposition 1 (Recovery of the Average Derivative) *Let* $f \in W^{1,1}(\Omega)$ *and let* w *be a trimming weight with* $\operatorname{supp}(w) \subseteq \Omega_{j,h_0}$ *for some* $h_0 > 0$*. Then:*

$$\lim_{h \downarrow 0} \theta_h(f) = \mathbb{E}\left[w(X)\, \partial_j f(X)\right] \tag{3.11}$$

If moreover $(w_m)_{m \ge 1}$ *is a sequence of trimming weights with* $w_m \uparrow 1$ *P-almost everywhere, then* $\mathbb{E}[w_m\, \partial_j f] \to \mathbb{E}[\partial_j f] = \mathrm{AME}_j$*.*

One weak derivative — the minimal regularity under which the classical estimand exists at all — is thus the only condition separating the window effect from the average derivative. Nothing about the fitted model appears in Proposition 1: the double limit concerns the estimand, not the estimator, and in practice one fixes h and reports the window effect, treating the proposition as the license to interpret it as a derivative summary when the truth is smooth.

Remark 2 (Binary and Categorical Variables) *For a binary* $X_j \in \{0, 1\}$ *the contrast estimand of Section 2 is* $\theta^{\mathrm{bin}} = \mathbb{E}[w(X_{-j})\{f(X_{-j}, 1) - f(X_{-j}, 0)\}]$*, and the same change-of-variables argument — with the integral over* x_j *replaced by a sum over its two support points — yields the representer:*

$$\alpha^{\mathrm{bin}}(u) = w(u_{-j}) \left[\frac{\mathbf{1}\{u_j = 1\}}{\pi(u_{-j})} - \frac{\mathbf{1}\{u_j = 0\}}{1 - \pi(u_{-j})}\right], \qquad \pi(x_{-j}) = \mathbb{P}(X_j = 1 \mid X_{-j} = x_{-j}) \tag{3.12}$$

These are inverse propensity weights, and the resulting orthogonal score is the augmented inverse probability weighting score of Robins et al. (1994) with X_j *in the role of the treatment. The overlap condition* $\varepsilon \le \pi \le 1 - \varepsilon$ *plays exactly the role the trimming weight plays in the continuous case, and every result of Section 3.4 applies verbatim with* (α_h, θ_h) *replaced by* $(\alpha^{\mathrm{bin}}, \theta^{\mathrm{bin}})$*. Continuous, binary, and categorical effects are thus instances of one construction rather than a definition and two patches.*

Orthogonal Score, Cross-Fitting, and Efficient Inference

The Riesz representation converts the estimand into a moment condition with an exact second-order bias. Define, for candidate functions $\tilde f, \tilde\alpha$ and scalar θ, the score:

$$\psi(x, y; \tilde f, \tilde\alpha, \theta) = w(x)\, \Delta_{j,h} \tilde f(x) + \tilde\alpha(x)\, \big(y - \tilde f(x)\big) - \theta \tag{3.13}$$

At the truth, $\mathbb{E}[\psi(X, Y; f, \alpha_h, \theta_h(f))] = 0$: the first term has mean $\theta_h(f)$ by definition and the correction term has conditional mean zero. The content of the construction is what happens away from the truth.

Lemma 2 (Exact Product Bias) *Let Assumption 1 hold and let* $\tilde f \in L^2(\Omega)$*,* $\tilde\alpha \in L^2(P)$*. Then:*

$$\mathbb{E}\left[\psi(X, Y; \tilde f, \tilde\alpha, \theta_h(f))\right] = \mathbb{E}\left[\big(\alpha_h(X) - \tilde\alpha(X)\big)\big(\tilde f(X) - f(X)\big)\right] \tag{3.14}$$

In particular the bias is bounded by $\|\alpha_h - \tilde\alpha\|_{P,2} \cdot \left\|\tilde f - f\right\|_{P,2}$*.*

Lemma 2 is an identity, not an expansion: because θ_h is linear in f, the moment bias equals the product of the two nuisance errors with no linearization remainder whatsoever. Neyman orthogonality — the vanishing of the Gateaux derivative of the moment in each nuisance direction at the truth (Chernozhukov et al., 2018) — is the special case obtained by setting one error to zero, but the exact form is stronger and is what makes the subsequent analysis short. The practical meaning: an error in the fitted learner harms the estimate only to the extent that the representer is also misestimated, and vice versa. It is this multiplication of errors, not any smoothness of the learner, that buys the parametric rate.

The estimator combines the score with cross-fitting. Partition $\{1, \dots, n\}$ into K folds $I_1, \dots, I_K$ of approximately equal size ($K = 5$ is the package default), and for each k let $\hat f^{(-k)}$ and $\hat\alpha^{(-k)}$ be estimates of f and α_h computed from the observations outside fold k — the learner exactly as in Section 2, the representer as described in Section 3.7. The debiased estimator is:

$$\hat\theta_h = \frac{1}{n} \sum_{k=1}^{K} \sum_{i \in I_k} \left[w(\mathbf{x}_i)\, \Delta_{j,h} \hat f^{(-k)}(\mathbf{x}_i) + \hat\alpha^{(-k)}(\mathbf{x}_i)\, \big(y_i - \hat f^{(-k)}(\mathbf{x}_i)\big)\right] \tag{3.15}$$

Cross-fitting decouples the randomness of the nuisance estimates from the observations at which the score is evaluated, so that no entropy or Donsker condition on the learner's function class is needed (Chernozhukov et al., 2018) — a point of substance here, since the function classes of boosted trees and deep networks are exactly the classes for which such conditions fail.

Assumption 3 For each fold k: (a) $\left\|\hat f^{(-k)} - f\right\|_{P,2} = o_p(1)$ and $\left\|\hat\alpha^{(-k)} - \alpha_h\right\|_{P,2} = o_p(1)$; (b) $\left\|\hat f^{(-k)} - f\right\|_{P,2} \cdot$

$\left\|\hat{\alpha}^{(-k)} - \alpha_h\right\|_{P,2} = o_p(n^{-1/2})$; (c) $\left\|\hat{\alpha}^{(-k)}\right\|_\infty \le \bar{A} < \infty$ almost surely.

Condition (c) is without loss of generality: α_h obeys the known bound of Lemma 1, so any estimate may be truncated at that bound without degrading its L^2 error. Conditions (a) and (b) are rate conditions on *regression-type* L^2 errors only. The sufficient condition for (b) that we verify for specific learners in Section 3.7 is that both nuisances converge faster than $n^{-1/4}$; the product form also permits trading accuracy in one nuisance against the other.

Under Assumption 2 in place of the density bounds, the three conditions are read as follows. Condition (a) is strengthened to $\left\|\hat{f}^{(-k)} - f\right\|_{P,2+\delta} = o_p(1)$ for a $\delta > 0$ with $(2+\delta)/2$ conjugate to the r of (3.2); condition (c) is replaced by $\left\|\hat{\alpha}^{(-k)}\right\|_{P,q} \le \bar{A}_q < \infty$ for the q of Assumption 2(c); and condition (b) is unchanged.

That last point is the one worth emphasizing. What changes between the two assumption sets are a consistency requirement and a boundedness requirement; the product condition (b), which governs how fast the nuisances must converge, is identical in both. The reason is the exactness of Lemma 2: the bias is a product of two L^2 errors with no linearization remainder to control, so the step of the argument that carries the rates never touches a density bound. Everything in Section 3.7 therefore applies verbatim under either assumption set. Had the bias carried the usual remainder term, the higher integrability would have propagated into the rate conditions and the thresholds of Section 3.7 would have moved.

Where the learner's error is uniformly bounded — as it is in the compactly supported settings in which the rate results of Section 3.7 are proved, whose estimators are truncated at a known bound on f — the strengthening of (a) is free. Writing $\Delta = \hat{f}^{(-k)} - f$, interpolation gives

$$\|\Delta\|_{P,2+\delta} \le \|\Delta\|_\infty^{\delta/(2+\delta)} \, \|\Delta\|_{P,2}^{2/(2+\delta)} \tag{3.16}$$

so L^2 consistency implies $L^{2+\delta}$ consistency with no additional assumption. On unbounded support it is a genuine additional requirement, though a mild one, and it holds for the learners used in the Gaussian design of Section 5.

Theorem 1, Theorem 2 and Proposition 2 hold under either assumption set. The proofs in the supplement carry the two cases side by side at the three points where they differ.

Theorem 1 (Asymptotic Linearity and Normality) *Let Assumptions 1 and 3 hold, write* $\psi_i = \psi(\mathbf{x}_i, y_i; f, \alpha_h, \theta_h(f))$, *and suppose* $V_h = \mathrm{Var}(\psi_i) > 0$. *Then:*

$$\sqrt{n}\,\big(\hat{\theta}_h - \theta_h(f)\big) = \frac{1}{\sqrt{n}} \sum_{i=1}^{n} \psi_i + o_p(1) \;\xrightarrow{d}\; N(0, V_h) \tag{3.17}$$

Moreover the plug-in variance estimator:

$$\hat{V}_h = \frac{1}{n} \sum_{k=1}^{K} \sum_{i \in I_k} \Big[w(\mathbf{x}_i)\, \Delta_{j,h} \hat{f}^{(-k)}(\mathbf{x}_i) + \hat{\alpha}^{(-k)}(\mathbf{x}_i)\, \big(y_i - \hat{f}^{(-k)}(\mathbf{x}_i)\big) - \hat{\theta}_h \Big]^2 \tag{3.18}$$

satisfies $\hat{V}_h \xrightarrow{p} V_h$.

No smoothness of the fitted learner appears anywhere in Theorem 1 or its proof. The only property of the finite difference operator that is used is that it is bounded on $L^2(P)$ after trimming:

$$\|w\, \Delta_{j,h} g\|_{P,2} \le \frac{1}{h} \left(\frac{p_{\max}}{p_{\min}}\right)^{1/2} \|g\|_{P,2} \tag{3.19}$$

so L^2 convergence of the learner transfers to L^2 convergence of its window effects automatically — precisely the step that fails for the derivative operator, which is unbounded on every L^p space, and the reason the classical route requires function-space convergence of the learner's gradient. The condition that the earlier version of this theory imposed at this point — root-n convergence of $\hat{f}_n$ to f in a Sobolev or BV norm — is not merely weakened but absent: it has been replaced by Assumption 3(b), a product of L^2 rates that growing-complexity learners can attain.

The exactness of Lemma 2 yields a second dividend beyond weakened rates: the score is doubly robust, and one direction of that robustness removes the consistency requirement on the learner altogether. Setting $\tilde{\alpha} = \alpha_h$ in Lemma 2 makes the moment bias vanish identically for *every* $\tilde{f}$ — not approximately, not at first order, but as an identity — and cross-fitting converts this into exact finite-sample unbiasedness of $\hat{\theta}_h$. The learner's failures are then paid entirely in variance, never in location.

Proposition 2 (Double Robustness: Inference without Learner Consistency) *Let Assumption 1 hold and suppose that for each fold: (a)* $\left\|\hat{f}^{(-k)} - g\right\|_{P,2} = o_p(1)$ *for some fixed* $g \in L^2(\Omega)$, *not necessarily equal to* f; *(b)* $\left\|\hat{\alpha}^{(-k)} - \alpha_h\right\|_{P,2} = o_p(n^{-1/2})$ — *in particular* $\hat{\alpha}^{(-k)} = \alpha_h$ *when the covariate density is known; and (c)* $\left\|\hat{\alpha}^{(-k)}\right\|_\infty \le \bar{A} < \infty$ *almost surely. Define* $m_g = w\, \Delta_{j,h} g + \alpha_h\,(\tilde{f} - g)$, *which satisfies* $\mathbb{E}[m_g(X)] = \theta_h(f)$ *for every* g, *and:*

$$V_h(g) = \mathrm{Var}\big(m_g(X)\big) + \mathbb{E}\big[\alpha_h(X)^2\, \sigma^2(X)\big] \tag{3.20}$$

If $V_h(g) > 0$, *then:*

$$\sqrt{n}\,\big(\hat{\theta}_h - \theta_h(f)\big) \;\xrightarrow{d}\; N\big(0, V_h(g)\big), \qquad \hat{V}_h \xrightarrow{p} V_h(g) \tag{3.21}$$

so the confidence intervals of Corollary 1 retain asymptotic coverage. When $\hat{\alpha}^{(-k)} = \alpha_h$ *exactly,* $\mathbb{E}[\hat{\theta}_h] = \theta_h(f)$ *at every sample size.*

The practical reach of Proposition 2 is wider than its hypotheses may suggest, because condition (a) is the condition that off-the-shelf machine learning defaults actually satisfy. A depth-capped forest, an early-stopped boosting run, a network of fixed width — fixed-complexity learners generally — converge not to f but to a pseudo-true limit g within their approximation class, so Assumption 3(a) fails and Theorem 1 is silent about them. The proposition covers exactly this case whenever the representer side is strong: in simulation designs and designed experiments the covariate density is known and α_h is computable in closed form; and in the binary case of Remark 2, a randomized X_j means a *known* propensity score, so the marginal effect of a randomized treatment is validly covered for any black-box learner with no consistency requirement whatsoever — the model-agnostic analog of the classical robustness of randomization (Robins et al., 1994). The mirror-image direction of the double robustness is worth

recording too: since the bias identity is symmetric, a learner converging at the parametric rate — a correctly specified GLM — tolerates an arbitrarily poor representer estimate, which is how the classical delta-method validity of parametric average marginal effects is nested here as the opposite corner of the same identity.

Two honest qualifications. First, when $g \neq f$ the estimator is asymptotically linear with influence function different from the efficient one; there is no conflict with Theorem 2 below, because such an estimator is not regular, and efficiency is restored exactly when $g = f$, at which point (3.20) reduces to the bound. The noise component of the variance is invariant in g; misspecification of the learner is paid entirely through the dispersion of m_g, typically as wider intervals. Second, in observational data the density is unknown and condition (b) demands a parametric-rate representer, which Riesz regression delivers only under strong structure; the proposition is therefore a complement to Theorem 1, not a replacement — the theorem splits the burden multiplicatively across the two nuisances, the proposition shifts it entirely onto one of them.

Theorem 2 (Semiparametric Efficiency) *Let Assumption 1 hold. In the nonparametric model in which the distribution of (X, Y) is restricted only by Assumption 1, the efficient influence function of the functional $P \mapsto \theta_h(f_P)$ is $\psi(x, y; f, \alpha_h, \theta_h(f))$, and the semiparametric efficiency bound is:*

$$V_h = \mathrm{Var}\big(w(X)\,\Delta_{j,h} f(X)\big) + \mathbb{E}\big[\alpha_h(X)^2\,\sigma^2(X)\big] \tag{3.22}$$

where $\sigma^2(x) = \mathrm{Var}(Y \mid X = x)$. The estimator $\hat{\theta}_h$ of Theorem 1 attains the bound.

The variance decomposition (3.22) is the honest accounting of what inference on a marginal effect costs. The first term is the heterogeneity of the effect itself across the covariate distribution — irreducible, present even if f were known. The second is the price of not knowing f: the conditional noise amplified by the squared representer, which scales as h^{-2} in the worst case through the bound of Lemma 1. Narrow windows purchase proximity to the derivative estimand at the cost of a larger efficiency bound — the bias–variance tradeoff of the problem, located in the estimand rather than hidden in an estimator's tuning. No estimator that is regular for θ_h can do better than (3.22); the question the earlier version of this theory could not answer — whether the procedure is optimal in any sense — has the sharpest available affirmative answer for the window estimand.

Corollary 1 (Confidence Intervals) *Under the conditions of Theorem 1, $\hat{\theta}_h \pm z_{1-\gamma/2}\,(\hat{V}_h/n)^{1/2}$ is an asymptotically valid $1-\gamma$ confidence interval for $\theta_h(f)$, and the associated t-statistic is asymptotically standard normal under $H_0 : \theta_h(f) = 0$.*

Remark 3 (Resampling-Free and Resampling-Based Inference) *Corollary 1 requires no resampling: the coefficient table of Section 2 is produced from a single pass of cross-fitting, with K model fits in place of the B refits of the bootstrap — a reduction of one to two orders of magnitude in computation. When a resampling distribution is nonetheless wanted (for simultaneous bands across coefficients, for example), asymptotic linearity delivers one for free: the multiplier bootstrap that perturbs the estimated influence function values $\hat{\psi}_i$ by i.i.d. mean-zero weights is consistent (van der Vaart and Wellner, 1996, Chapter 3.6) under the conditions of Theorem 1, and costs no additional model fits.*

Remark 4 (The Model-Refitting Bootstrap) *The refitting bootstrap of Section 2, applied to the uncorrected plug-in average, is not covered by these guarantees, for two reasons that the present framework makes visible. First, it recenters at the fitted model, so it measures variability around $\mathbb{E}[w\Delta_{j,h}\hat{f}]$ rather than around $\theta_h(f)$: the regularization bias $\mathbb{E}[\alpha_h(\hat{f} - f)]$ — first order for slowly converging learners — is invisible to it. This is the mechanism behind the collapse of random forest coverage documented in Section 5. Second, evaluating each refitted model at the original sample holds the empirical covariate distribution fixed and thereby omits the first variance component of* (3.22) *from the bootstrap distribution. The refitting bootstrap retains a legitimate role as a diagnostic for how far the fitted function moves under resampling, variability which the asymptotic theory conditions away; it should be read as that diagnostic, not as the inferential procedure.*

What Learner Gradients Estimate

The inference theory of Section 3.4 used no property of the fitted learner beyond an L^2 rate. The question it leaves open is interpretive: the first component of the score averages the finite differences of the fitted model, and one wants to know what that object measures about the model — and when the model's gradient information converges to the population's. This subsection answers both questions in the function spaces the learners naturally inhabit. Four lemmas establish that gradients exist and converge in the Sobolev space of smooth estimators and the BV space of piecewise constant ones; a pairing identity (Theorem 3) then expresses the window effect of any BV estimator exactly as its jump measure integrated against a locally averaged covariate density, which is, to our knowledge, the first characterization of the population quantity that the marginal effect of a tree-based model measures. All proofs are in the supplement.

The parallel structure of Lemmas 3 through 6 reflects the parallel structure of the Sobolev and BV frameworks and is the formal expression of the analogy between smooth and piecewise constant estimators. None of these results is needed for the validity of Theorem 1; they characterize the regime in which the *uncorrected* plug-in average is already consistent, and hence in which the correction term of (3.15) is a refinement rather than a repair.

Lemma 3 (Derivative Existence in Sobolev Spaces) *Let $\hat{f}_n \in W^{2,p}(\Omega)$ for some $p > 1$. Then $\nabla \hat{f}_n \in W^{1,p}(\Omega)^d$ exists as a well defined L^p function and satisfies:*

$$\left\|\nabla \hat{f}_n\right\|_{L^p} \leq \left\|\hat{f}_n\right\|_{W^{1,p}} \leq \left\|\hat{f}_n\right\|_{W^{2,p}} \tag{3.23}$$

Lemma 3 is essentially definitional—membership in $W^{2,p}(\Omega)$ implies by definition that the first and second weak derivatives exist and are in L^p. The content of the lemma is the norm bound, which establishes that the gradient operator $\nabla : W^{2,p} \to W^{1,p}$ is bounded and linear. This boundedness is what makes the subsequent consistency argument work—a bounded linear operator preserves convergence, so once we have convergence of $\hat{f}_n$ in the right space, convergence of $\nabla \hat{f}_n$

follows automatically. The reason we require $\hat{f}_n \in W^{2,p}(\Omega)$ rather than just $W^{1,p}(\Omega)$ is that we need one additional degree of differentiability to apply the compactness argument in Lemma 4. The relevant theory of Sobolev spaces and their norms is developed in Evans (2010, Chapter 5).

Lemma 4 (Derivative Consistency in Sobolev Spaces) *Let $f \in W^{1,p}(\Omega)$ and suppose $\hat{f}_n$ is well-behaved in the Sobolev sense. Then:*

$$\left\|\nabla \hat{f}_n - \nabla f\right\|_{L^p} \xrightarrow{p} 0 \tag{3.24}$$

Lemma 4 is the harder result and the one that does the real work in the Sobolev setting. The difficulty is that L^p consistency of $\hat{f}_n$ alone does not imply L^p consistency of $\nabla \hat{f}_n$—differentiation is an unbounded operator on L^p and limits and derivatives cannot be exchanged without additional structure. The uniform $W^{2,p}(\Omega)$ boundedness condition provides that structure. The proof applies the Rellich–Kondrachov compact embedding theorem, which states that a uniformly bounded sequence in $W^{2,p}(\Omega)$ has a subsequence converging strongly in $W^{1,p}(\Omega)$ (Evans, 2010, Theorem 5, Section 5.7). Combined with the L^p consistency condition identifying the limit as f, this gives strong convergence of $\hat{f}_n$ to f in $W^{1,p}(\Omega)$, from which L^p convergence of the gradients follows immediately from the boundedness of ∇ established in Lemma 3. The key insight is that the uniform boundedness condition ensures the estimator sequence lives in a compact subset of $W^{1,p}(\Omega)$, preventing the gradients from escaping to infinity even as the estimator fits the data more closely.

Lemma 5 (Derivative Existence in BV) *Let $\hat{f}_n \in BV(\Omega)$. Then the distributional gradient $D\hat{f}_n$ exists as a well defined vector valued Radon measure in $\mathcal{M}(\Omega)^d$ with:*

$$|D\hat{f}_n|(\Omega) < \infty \tag{3.25}$$

For piecewise constant estimators with leaf partition $\{R_j\}$ and leaf means $\{\bar{y}_j\}$, the distributional gradient takes the explicit form:

$$D\hat{f}_n = \sum_{j \sim k} (\bar{y}_k - \bar{y}_j) \cdot \nu_{jk} \cdot \mathcal{H}^{d-1} \lfloor_{\partial R_j \cap \partial R_k} \tag{3.26}$$

where ν_{jk} is the unit normal between adjacent leaves and $\mathcal{H}^{d-1}$ is the $(d-1)$-dimensional Hausdorff measure on leaf boundaries.

Lemma 5 is the BV analog of Lemma 3 and is similarly structural in nature. The first part—that BV membership implies the distributional gradient exists as a Radon measure—follows from the definition of BV as developed in Ambrosio et al. (2000, Chapter 3). The content of the lemma is the explicit formula for piecewise constant estimators, which makes concrete what the distributional gradient actually looks like for a tree based model. The formula says that the gradient is not a function at all but a measure concentrated on the boundaries between leaves, with mass proportional to the jump in response values across the boundary weighted by the boundary surface area. This is the precise sense in which a random forest or boosted tree has a gradient—not a pointwise derivative, which does not exist, but a distributional object that captures where and how much the estimator changes. This explicit representation is also what makes the total variation $|D\hat{f}_n|(\Omega)$ computable in terms of observable quantities—the leaf means and the partition geometry—which is essential for verifying the well-behaved condition in the theorems below.

Lemma 6 (Derivative Consistency in BV) *Let $f \in W^{1,p}(\Omega)$ for some $p > 1$, so that $f \in BV(\Omega)$ with $Df = \nabla f \cdot \mathcal{L}^d$. Suppose $\hat{f}_n$ is well-behaved in the BV sense. Then:*

$$D\hat{f}_n \xrightarrow{w*} Df \quad \text{in } \mathcal{M}(\Omega)^d \tag{3.27}$$

If additionally $\mathbb{E}[|D\hat{f}_n|(\Omega)] \to |Df|(\Omega)$, then convergence is strict.

Lemma 6 is the hardest of the four function space lemmas and the BV analog of Lemma 4. The convergence is necessarily weaker than in the Sobolev case—weak-$*$ convergence of measures rather than strong L^p convergence—because the BV space is not reflexive and the stronger norm convergence is not available in general. Weak-$*$ convergence means that for any continuous test function ϕ:

$$\int_\Omega \phi \, d(D\hat{f}_n) \to \int_\Omega \phi \, d(Df) \tag{3.28}$$

which is the appropriate notion of convergence for the distributional gradients of piecewise constant estimators. In the context of average marginal effects, this means that integrated gradient information—which is exactly what the AME computes— converges to the correct population quantity. The proof applies the BV compactness theorem of Ambrosio et al. (2000, Theorem 3.23), which is the analog of Rellich–Kondrachov in the BV setting: a uniformly bounded sequence in BV has a subsequence converging in L^1, and the L^1 consistency condition identifies the limit as f. The strict convergence upgrade follows from the lower semicontinuity of the total variation functional and is the stronger result one would want for applications requiring convergence of the total size of gradient information rather than just its distribution.

The parallel between Lemmas 4 and 6 is worth noting explicitly. In both cases the argument has the same structure: uniform boundedness in a strong space gives compactness, consistency in a weak space identifies the limit, and the combination gives convergence of the derivative in the appropriate topology. The difference is in the topology of the conclusion—strong L^p convergence in the Sobolev case, weak-$*$ convergence of measures in the BV case—and this difference is fundamental rather than technical. It reflects the fact that smooth estimators carry gradient information in a stronger sense than piecewise constant estimators, which is itself a reflection of the different inductive biases of the estimator classes.

The pairing identity is the capstone of the interpretation theory. Recall from Lemma 5 that the distributional gradient of a piecewise constant estimator is a measure concentrated on leaf boundaries. The window effect of such an estimator integrates that measure against a smoothed density: let $K_h \star q$ denote the one-dimensional moving average of $q = wp$ (extended by zero) along coordinate j:

$$(K_h \star q)(u) = \frac{1}{2h} \int_{-h}^{h} q(u + s\, e_j)\, ds \tag{3.29}$$

Theorem 3 (Pairing Identity) *Let Assumption 1 hold, let w be a trimming weight with $\text{supp}(w) \subseteq \Omega_{j,h}$, and let $g \in BV(\Omega)$*

(identified with its precise representative). Then:

$$\mathbb{E}\left[w(X)\,\Delta_{j,h}g(X)\right] = \int_{\Omega} (K_h \star q)(u)\; dD_j g(u) \tag{3.30}$$

where $D_j g$ is the j-th component of the distributional gradient of g. In particular, for a piecewise constant g with leaf partition $\{R_l\}$ and leaf values $\{\bar{y}_l\}$, by Lemma 5:

$$\mathbb{E}\left[w(X)\,\Delta_{j,h}g(X)\right] = \sum_{l\sim m} (\bar{y}_m - \bar{y}_l)\,(\nu_{lm})_j \int_{\partial R_l \cap \partial R_m} (K_h \star q)\; d\mathcal{H}^{d-1} \tag{3.31}$$

Corollary 2 *If in addition q extends to a continuous function of compact support (for instance w continuous and p continuous on Ω), then for fixed $g \in BV(\Omega)$:*

$$\lim_{h\downarrow 0} \int_{\Omega} (K_h \star q)\; dD_j g = \int_{\Omega} q\; dD_j g \tag{3.32}$$

and when $g \in W^{1,1}(\Omega)$ the right side equals $\mathbb{E}[w(X)\,\partial_j g(X)]$, consistent with Proposition 1.

Theorem 3 settles a question that the interpretability literature has left informal: what does the average marginal effect of a random forest *measure*? The answer given by (3.31) is exact and geometric: it is the total jump of the fitted surface across leaf boundaries in direction j, with each boundary segment weighted by its share of the covariate mass in an h-window — the places where the model changes its prediction, weighted by how many observations live near those places. The identity reconciles the two readings of a marginal effect that Section 2 could only juxtapose. Read with $g = \hat{f}$, (3.30) is a descriptive statement about the fitted model, available in finite samples with no assumptions at all. Read through Theorem 1, the same plug-in quantity, corrected by the orthogonal score, estimates the population functional $\theta_h(f)$ at the parametric rate. The descriptive and the inferential interpretations are the two sides of (3.15), and the pairing identity is what makes the first of them precise.

Gradient Convergence of Specific Learners

The theorems of this subsection verify the well-behaved conditions for three estimator classes and conclude, via the lemma pairs above, that the learner's own gradient information converges to the population's. This is the strongest interpretability property a learner can have — the fitted model's local behavior, not merely its window averages, tracks the truth — and it implies consistency of the uncorrected plug-in average for the small-h estimand. We emphasize the division of labor: these results calibrate how much interpretive weight the fitted gradients themselves can bear, while the inference of Section 3.4 requires none of them. In each case the argument has two components: verifying that the estimator satisfies the well-behaved condition, and citing the appropriate lemma pair. The first component is the estimator-specific contribution; the second is the functional analytic machinery established above.

Theorem 4 (Gradient Consistency for Neural Networks) *Let $\hat{f}_n$ be a neural network estimator with smooth activations $\sigma \in C^2$, bounded weight norms $\sup_n \prod_\ell \left\|W_\ell^{(n)}\right\| < \infty$, and $\left\|\hat{f}_n - f\right\|_{L^p} \xrightarrow{p} 0$ for $p > d$. Then $\hat{f}_n$ is well-behaved in the Sobolev sense and:*

$$\left\|\nabla \hat{f}_n - \nabla f\right\|_{L^p} \xrightarrow{p} 0 \tag{3.33}$$

The conditions of Theorem 4 are natural and verifiable. Smooth activations — sigmoid, tanh, GELU — are standard in practice and ensure the network function is twice differentiable. The bounded weight norm condition formalizes the effect of L^2 regularization during training, which prevents the network weights from growing without bound. The L^p consistency condition is the standard requirement that the network is learning the true function. Hornik et al. (1990) establish that multilayer feedforward networks with smooth activation functions are capable of approximating an arbitrary function and its derivatives to arbitrary accuracy, providing the foundation for the consistency condition and establishing that the function class is rich enough to contain the estimators we consider. The condition $p > d$ is required by the pointwise differentiability theorem of Evans and Gariepy (2015, Theorem 6.5) and is satisfied for all p larger than the covariate dimension — a mild regularity condition that is implicit in the classical Sobolev embedding theory.

Proof sketch The chain rule applied through the network layers gives $\hat{f}_n \in W^{2,p}(\Omega)$ with:

$$\left\|\hat{f}_n\right\|_{W^{2,p}} \lesssim \prod_{\ell} \left\|W_\ell^{(n)}\right\|^2 \cdot \left\|\sigma''\right\|_\infty \tag{3.34}$$

which is uniformly bounded by the weight norm assumption. The L^p consistency condition and Lemma 4 then give the result. Full proof in Section S15 of the supplement. □

Remark 5 *Theorem 4 is stated for smooth activations. ReLU networks require a modified argument because ReLU is not C^2 and the chain rule calculation does not apply directly. Extension to ReLU networks is possible through a distributional argument but complicates the presentation and is omitted here.*

Theorem 5 (Gradient Consistency for Gradient Boosted Models) *Let $\hat{f}_n = \hat{F}_m = (I - (I - S)^{m+1})Y$ be an L_2Boost estimator with symmetric linear learner S satisfying the eigenvalue condition $0 < \lambda_k \leq 1$ for all k, and with base learners h_m that are either smooth ($h_m \in W^{2,p}$) or tree stumps. Suppose $\left\|\hat{f}_n - f\right\|_{L^1} \xrightarrow{p} 0$. Then:*

(i) If base learners are smooth, $\hat{f}_n$ is well-behaved in the Sobolev sense and $\left\|\nabla \hat{f}_n - \nabla f\right\|_{L^p} \xrightarrow{p} 0$.

(ii) If base learners are tree stumps, $\hat{f}_n$ is well-behaved in the BV sense and $D\hat{f}_n \xrightarrow{w*} Df$ in $\mathcal{M}(\Omega)^d$.

Theorem 5 covers both cases that arise in practice and illustrates how the function space framework adapts to the base learner. XGBoost and LightGBM — the implementations used in Section 3 — use shallow trees as base learners and therefore fall under case (ii). The two cases in the theorem are not merely technical alternatives — they reflect a genuine difference in what the gradient of the estimator is. For smooth base learners the gradient is an ordinary function and L^p convergence is available. For tree base learners the gradient is a measure and only weak-$*$ convergence can be established. The average marginal effects are well defined and consistent in both cases, but the sense in which they are consistent differs.

The eigenvalue condition $0 < \lambda_k \leq 1$ is the key regularity condition on the base learner. Bühlmann and Yu (2003) impose this condition explicitly in their Theorem 1 and establish that under it the bias decays exponentially fast while the

variance increases only by exponentially diminishing amounts — the exponential bias–variance trade-off that makes L_2Boost analytically tractable. The condition holds for smoothing spline learners and, generically, for tree stump learners whose splits have positive but incomplete explanatory power, which is the typical case in practice. Learners with any eigenvalue equal to zero are degenerate in the sense of Corollary 1 of Bühlmann and Yu (2003): $\mathcal{B}_m \equiv S$ for all m and boosting does not improve on the base learner. The functional gradient descent perspective of Mason et al. (2000) provides the conceptual framework for understanding the boosting path as gradient descent in function space.

Proof sketch For smooth base learners the $W^{2,p}(\Omega)$ bound follows from linearity of the estimator:

$$\left\|\hat{f}_n\right\|_{W^{2,p}} \leq \sum_m \eta_m \|h_m\|_{W^{2,p}} < \infty \tag{3.35}$$

For tree stump base learners the BV bound uses the eigenvalue structure of L_2Boost. By Proposition 1 of Bühlmann and Yu (2003), the residual at step m is $u_m = (I - S)^m Y$. By Proposition 2, under the eigenvalue condition $0 < \lambda_k \leq 1$, Theorem 1 of Bühlmann and Yu (2003) gives exponential decay of residuals:

$$\|u_m\|_{L^2} \leq C\rho^m, \quad \rho = \max_k(1 - \lambda_k) < 1 \tag{3.36}$$

Each stump's BV norm is controlled by its residual magnitude via Lemma 5, and the total BV norm of the ensemble satisfies:

$$\mathbb{E}[|D\hat{f}_n|(\Omega)] \leq C \sum_{m=1}^{\infty} \rho^m = \frac{C\rho}{1-\rho} < \infty \tag{3.37}$$

The geometric series converges because $\rho < 1$, giving uniform BV boundedness without any step size condition. Lemma 6 then gives $D\hat{f}_n \xrightarrow{w*} Df$. Full proof in Section S16 of the supplement. □

Theorem 6 (Gradient Consistency for Mondrian Forests) *Let $\hat{f}_n$ be a Mondrian random forest estimator with budget $\lambda_n \asymp n^{1/(d+2)}$, $B \gg n^{2(d-\alpha)/(d+2)}$ trees where $\alpha = 1 - d/p$, f Lipschitz on $[0,1]^d$, and $f \in W^{1,p}(\Omega)$ for $p > d$. Then $\hat{f}_n$ is well-behaved in the BV sense and:*

$$D\hat{f}_n \xrightarrow{w*} Df \quad \text{in } \mathcal{M}(\Omega)^d \tag{3.38}$$

Theorem 6 is the most technically demanding result in the paper. Random forests are genuinely different from neural networks and boosted models in a way that makes gradient consistency harder to establish — the partition structure is random and the response averages within leaves depend on the data in a complex way. The restriction to Mondrian forests, where splits are made independently of the data, is the key simplification that makes the proof tractable. For Mondrian forests the partition geometry and the response variation can be controlled separately, whereas for Breiman forests with data-dependent splits the two are coupled in a way that resists clean analysis. The L^2 consistency result under the budget $\lambda_n \asymp n^{1/(d+2)}$ follows from Mourtada et al. (2017), who establish the minimax rate $O(n^{-2/(d+2)})$ for Lipschitz regression functions, and L^1 consistency follows by Cauchy–Schwarz on the bounded domain Ω.

The budget condition $\lambda_n \asymp n^{1/(d+2)}$ and the tree count condition $B \gg n^{2(d-\alpha)/(d+2)}$ are natural and interpretable. The budget determines the approximation rate — balancing the bias from coarse partitions against the variance from fine partitions at the minimax optimal rate. The tree count condition ensures that the forest average has sufficient cancellation across trees to control the total variation; it is mild in practice, satisfied by standard forest sizes for moderate dimension and sample size.

Proof sketch Each tree is piecewise constant and therefore in BV by Lemma 5. The key difficulty is that individual tree BV norms grow with n, so the triangle inequality applied to the forest average is too crude. Instead we work with the second moment of the total variation. Writing $D\hat{f}_n = \frac{1}{B}\sum_b DT_b$:

$$\mathbb{E}[|D\hat{f}_n|(\Omega)] \leq \sqrt{\mathbb{E}[|D\hat{f}_n|(\Omega)^2]} = \sqrt{\frac{1}{B^2}\mathbb{E}\left[\left|\sum_b DT_b\right|(\Omega)^2\right]} \tag{3.39}$$

The cross terms between trees $b \neq b'$ vanish by independence of the Mondrian partitions and the zero-mean condition on the jumps. The diagonal terms are bounded using the cell diameter result $\mathbb{E}[D_{\lambda_n}(x)^2] \leq 4d/\lambda_n^2$ of Roy and Teh (2009) and the split count bound $\mathbb{E}[K_{\lambda_n}] \leq (e(\lambda_n + 1))^d$ of Mourtada et al. (2017), giving:

$$\mathbb{E}[|D\hat{f}_n|(\Omega)^2] = \frac{1}{B}\mathbb{E}[|DT_1|(\Omega)^2] \leq \frac{1}{B}O(n^{2(d-\alpha)/(d+2)}) \tag{3.40}$$

Under the condition $B \gg n^{2(d-\alpha)/(d+2)}$ this is uniformly bounded. Lemma 6 then gives $D\hat{f}_n \xrightarrow{w*} Df$ in $\mathcal{M}(\Omega)^d$. Full proof in Section S17 of the supplement. □

Remark 6 *Extension of Theorem 6 to Breiman forests with data-dependent splits requires additional control over the interaction between partition geometry and response variation. The data-dependent splitting rule couples these two quantities in a way that makes the cross-term cancellation argument unavailable — splits are chosen precisely to maximize response differences across boundaries, which is the worst case for BV control. This extension is an important direction for future work and is discussed further in Section 6.*

Nuisance Estimation and Rates

Assumption 3 asks for two regression-type L^2 rates whose product is $o_p(n^{-1/2})$; the benchmark sufficient condition is that each nuisance converge faster than $n^{-1/4}$. This subsection records when the learners of Section 2 meet the benchmark for $\hat{f}$, and how the representer α_h is estimated without ever estimating a density.

For the regression function, the required rates are exactly the L^2 risk bounds of the modern nonparametric literature, and a single smoothness threshold organizes all three learner classes. For deep neural networks with ReLU activations, Schmidt-Hieber (2020) establishes the rate $n^{-s/(2s+d)}$ up to logarithmic factors for s-Hölder regression functions (with the effective d reduced under compositional structure), so the $n^{-1/4}$ benchmark is met precisely when:

$$\frac{s}{2s+d} > \frac{1}{4} \quad \Longleftrightarrow \quad s > \frac{d}{2} \tag{3.41}$$

For Mondrian forests, the minimax-optimal rates of Mourtada et al. (2017) take the same form $n^{-s/(2s+d)}$ for Hölder smoothness $s \leq 2$, so the benchmark is again (3.41): at Lipschitz smoothness $s = 1$ this requires $d < 2$, and

exploiting forest smoothing up to $s = 2$ accommodates $d \leq 3$. For L_2Boost, Bühlmann and Yu (2003) establish minimax rates for smoothing-spline base learners with the boosting iteration acting as the regularization parameter, and the benchmark corresponds to smoothness exceeding one half in their univariate and additive settings — with additive structure, as usual, breaking the dependence on the ambient dimension. The reading we intend is not that these conditions are innocuous — (3.41) is a real restriction, and in high dimensions it binds — but that the currency in which the conditions are denominated has changed: what inference requires of the learner is an L^2 error rate of the kind the learning-theory literature actually proves, rather than root-n convergence in a Sobolev norm, which no growing-complexity learner satisfies. For Breiman forests with data-dependent splits, L^2 consistency is available under structural assumptions (Scornet et al., 2015), and polynomial L^2 rates for the original algorithm — sample CART splits and column subsampling included — have been established under sufficient-impurity-decrease conditions by Chi et al. (2022); the resulting exponents can fall short of the $n^{-1/4}$ benchmark, but the product form of Assumption 3(b) permits pairing a slow forest rate with a fast representer estimate, and Proposition 2 covers the known-representer case with no forest rate at all. The open question relevant to this paper is therefore an L^2 rate question, a substantially more tractable target than the gradient-consistency question that Section 3.6 leaves open for that class.

The representer is estimated by Riesz regression (Chernozhukov et al., 2022), which exploits the same linearity that produced Lemma 2. By Lemma 1, for any candidate $\alpha \in L^2(P)$:

$$\mathbb{E}\left[\alpha(X)^2\right] - 2\,\mathbb{E}\left[w(X)\,\Delta_{j,h}\alpha(X)\right] = \|\alpha - \alpha_h\|_{P,2}^2 - \|\alpha_h\|_{P,2}^2 \tag{3.42}$$

so the population loss on the left is minimized uniquely at α_h, and its sample analog:

$$\hat{L}(\alpha) = \frac{1}{n}\sum_{i=1}^{n}\left[\alpha(\mathbf{x}_i)^2 - 2\,w(\mathbf{x}_i)\,\frac{\alpha(\mathbf{x}_i + he_j) - \alpha(\mathbf{x}_i - he_j)}{2h}\right] \tag{3.43}$$

is computable directly: minimizing $\hat{L}$ over a class of functions — penalized linear sieves, neural networks, or forests — requires only the ability to evaluate candidates at shifted points, and at no stage is the density p, let alone a derivative of it, estimated. Chernozhukov et al. (2022) provide L^2 convergence guarantees for such estimators over exactly these classes, with rates governed by the complexity of the class and the approximability of α_h. Since α_h obeys the explicit bound of Lemma 1, the minimizer is truncated at that bound, which enforces Assumption 3(c) by construction without affecting the L^2 error. Two further remarks. First, the product form of Assumption 3(b) permits asymmetry: a learner with a fast rate for f tolerates a slow Riesz estimate, and conversely. Second, in designed or simulated data where the covariate density is known — as in the Monte Carlo study of Section 5 — α_h is available in closed form and the representer error is identically zero; Proposition 2 then applies, and valid inference requires no rate — indeed no consistency — from the learner at all.

Verifying a New Learner

The architecture above is deliberately modular, and it is worth stating plainly what a reader must check to bring a learner not treated here under the results. There are two obligations, and they are separate. Valid inference requires only an $L^2(P)$ convergence rate for $\hat{f}$ fast enough that its product with the representer rate is $o_p(n^{-1/2})$, the benchmark sufficient condition being $n^{-1/4}$ for each. Nothing else about the learner enters Theorem 1: not differentiability, not the existence of a gradient, not membership in any particular function space. Consistency of the learner's own gradient information — the object of Section 3.6 — is a separate question, required only if one wishes to interpret the uncorrected plug-in, and it is answered by identifying the natural function space of the estimator class and applying the appropriate compactness theorem.

The practical consequence is that adding a learner is usually a matter of locating an existing rate rather than proving a new theorem. Table 1 records the position for the classes treated here and for several that are not. Penalized linear estimators are the easiest case: the lasso attains L^2 rates of order $\sqrt{s \log d / n}$ under standard sparsity and restricted-eigenvalue conditions, comfortably inside the benchmark whenever $s \log d = o(\sqrt{n})$, and it is a linear estimator in a Sobolev space, so both obligations are discharged by citation. Smoothing splines and series estimators are similar on both counts, attaining the classical $n^{-s/(2s+1)}$ rate in the univariate case and living in $W^{1,p}$ by construction. Kernel ridge regression over a reproducing kernel Hilbert space — the function space generated by the chosen kernel, in which evaluation at a point is a continuous linear functional — has minimax L^2 rates of the same form. For a sufficiently smooth kernel that space embeds continuously in $W^{1,p}$, so the interpretation argument of Section 3.6 applies unchanged; for a kernel that is not smooth it need not, and the embedding is the thing to check. Generalized additive models inherit the univariate rate componentwise, which is what makes additive structure so useful here: it breaks the dependence on ambient dimension in (3.41). For support vector regression with a smooth kernel and for Bayesian additive regression trees, L^2 rates are available under conditions in the respective literatures, though in the latter case posterior contraction rather than a frequentist risk bound is the natural object and the translation requires care. Any learner of bounded variation — which includes every tree-based method, however its splits are chosen — falls under the pairing identity of Theorem 3 without further argument, so what its window effect measures is characterized even when its rate is unknown.

Two cases in the table deserve separate mention because they are where the framework is currently incomplete. Breiman forests have the inference obligation open and the interpretation obligation conjectured, for the reasons given above. Learners whose output is not a fixed function of the data — online or streaming estimators, for instance — fall outside the sampling framework of Assumption 1 altogether and would require a different treatment.

Empirical Examples

Of the three applications introduced in Section 1, the credit default data are reported in full here, being the sharpest of the three for the purpose at hand. Adult Income and Ames Housing are reported in Sections S1 and S2 of the supplement; the design, the model classes and the window settings set out below are common to all three, and the conclusions drawn from the credit default data hold in the other two.

Table 1. What must be verified to apply the framework to a learner. The inference column is what Theorem 1 consumes; the interpretation column is what Section 3.6 requires in order to read the uncorrected plug-in as a gradient.

Learner	Inference: L^2 rate	Interpretation: function space
Linear and GLM	parametric	$W^{1,p}$, exact
Lasso, ridge	established	$W^{1,p}$
Splines, series	established	$W^{1,p}$
Kernel ridge	established	$W^{1,p}$ via smooth kernel
GAM	componentwise	$W^{1,p}$
Neural networks	established	$W^{1,p}$, proved here
Gradient boosting	established	BV, proved here
Mondrian forests	minimax optimal	BV, proved here
Breiman forests	*open*	BV; gradient *conjectured*
SVM (smooth kernel)	available	$W^{1,p}$ via kernel; not treated
BART	contraction rate	BV; not treated

Across the three empirical applications we fit four model classes: logistic or linear regression as the parametric baseline, a random forest, XGBoost, and a feedforward neural network. The random forest uses 200 trees with a maximum depth of 8. XGBoost uses 200 boosting rounds with a maximum depth of 4 and a learning rate of 0.05. The neural network architecture and training schedule depend on the outcome type. For binary classification, the network is a feedforward architecture with two hidden layers of 64 and 32 units trained with the Adam optimizer at a learning rate of 10^{-3}, with early stopping on a 10% validation split with patience of 20 epochs. For continuous regression, the network is deeper — four hidden layers of 256, 128, 64, and 32 units — trained at a learning rate of 3×10^{-4} with patience of 50 epochs, reflecting the larger capacity required to fit the continuous outcome surface and the longer training horizon needed for the optimization to converge. For regression outcomes, the network includes the input normalization layer and target standardization wrapper described in Section 2 to ensure scale-invariant gradient updates and predictions on the natural outcome scale. Estimation follows the debiased cross-fitted procedure of Section 2.4 with $K = 5$ folds: within each fold the learner and the Riesz representer are fit on the other four folds and evaluated on the held-out fold, and standard errors come from the sample variance of the orthogonal score. No learner is ever differenced at an observation it was trained on. Every model class is refit from scratch on each fold, including the neural networks, whose early stopping schedule is applied within the fold. The fit statistics reported at the foot of each table are computed from a single full-sample fit and are descriptive of the learner rather than of the estimator; they are not used in the estimation. Where applicable, predicted probabilities for classification models are extracted from `predict_proba(X)[:,1]` as discussed in Section 2.

The window estimand requires two settings to be fixed before estimation, and because $\theta_{j,h}$ is defined by them they are reported rather than treated as tuning. The step size is the default $h_j = \max(10^{-4}, 0.05\hat{\sigma}_j)$, floored at 0.5 for integer-valued features. The floor matters for count variables such as bedrooms, bathrooms, years of education and months delayed: a count has no mass strictly between its levels, so a window narrower than one unit has an empty interior, and for a piecewise constant learner the difference across it vanishes except where the window happens to straddle a split. At $h_j = 0.5$ the window is exactly the one-unit contrast, which is also the quantity of substantive interest for a count. The second setting is the trimming weight, which gives weight zero to observations lying within h_j of the boundary of the observed support of x_j, where $x \pm h_j e_j$ would require the learner to extrapolate. For most features this removes a negligible share of the sample, but for variables with mass sitting exactly on a boundary it does not: capital gains and capital losses are zero for over ninety percent of the Adult sample, and zero is the minimum of their observed support, so those AMEs are effects on the subpopulation with nonzero gains or losses rather than on the full sample. Table 2 reports h_j and the trimmed fraction for every feature in the three applications, and the discussion below flags the cases where the trimming is large enough to change the interpretation.

UCI Credit Default

The second dataset is the UCI Default of Credit Card Clients dataset (Yeh, 2009; Dua and Graff, 2019), comprising 30,000 observations of Taiwanese credit card holders. The outcome is whether a cardholder defaulted on their payment in the following month. Features are organized into demographics (age, sex, education, marital status), payment history (average payment status, months delayed), and bill and payment amounts (average bill amount, average payment amount, payment ratio). The specification search considers logistic regression and a TensorFlow neural network, providing a direct comparison between a classical parametric model and a deep learning approach on the same inferential task. Two features here carry substantial trimming. Months delayed takes seven integer values and 70.9% of the sample sits on one of the two outer ones, so its effect is identified among cardholders strictly inside that range; education takes four levels and is trimmed at 36.8%. Both take the floored step size $h_j = 0.5$, so their reported effects are one-level contrasts. The payment ratio, which turns out to carry the largest effect in the application, is continuous and trimmed at 18.4%.

Table 3 presents the specification search. The dominant finding is the importance of payment history and of the payment ratio. Months delayed enters at 0.035 for logistic regression and 0.030 for the neural network in specification A+B and remains at 0.030 and 0.025 in the full specification, while the payment ratio, once it is available in specifications A+C and A+B+C, is much the largest effect in the table: -0.265 for logistic regression and -0.194 for the neural network in the full specification. The demographic panel tells a different story from the Adult Income dataset of Section S1: age is statistically indistinguishable from zero in nearly every specification for both models, and the female indicator, while consistently negative and significant, shrinks substantially once

Table 2. Window settings for the empirical applications. Step size h_j and the fraction of observations receiving trimming weight zero.

Dataset	Feature	h_j	Trimmed
UCI Adult Income	age	0.6855	1.3%
	female	—	0.0%
	education_num	0.5	1.4%
	hours_per_week	0.6196	0.3%
	government	—	0.0%
	self_employed	—	0.0%
	white_collar	—	0.0%
	blue_collar	—	0.0%
	service	—	0.0%
	capital_gain	373	92.3%
	capital_loss	20.15	95.3%
	married	—	0.0%
UCI Credit Card Default	age	0.5	0.2%
	female	—	0.0%
	education	0.5	36.8%
	married	—	0.0%
	avg_pay_status	0.04911	7.0%
	months_delayed	0.5	70.9%
	avg_bill_amt	3,163	0.0%
	avg_pay_amt	507	11.7%
	pay_ratio	0.01839	18.4%
Ames Housing	GrLivArea	26.27	0.1%
	BedroomAbvGr	0.5	0.5%
	FullBath	0.5	2.9%
	HalfBath	0.5	63.4%
	OverallQual	0.5	1.4%
	OverallCond	0.5	1.6%
	YearBuilt	1.51	1.4%
	YearRemodAdd	1.032	14.5%
	LotArea	499	1.2%
	GarageArea	10.69	5.6%
	nbhd_high	—	0.0%
	nbhd_mid	—	0.0%

Notes: h_j is the default adaptive step size, $\max(10^{-4}, 0.05\hat{\sigma}_j)$, floored at 0.5 for integer-valued features so that a count is contrasted over a whole unit. Features declared binary use the level contrast $f(x \mid x_j = 1) - f(x \mid x_j = 0)$, for which h_j is undefined and no trimming applies. The trimmed fraction is the share of observations lying within h_j of the boundary of the observed support of x_j, which receive weight zero; for those features the estimand is the window effect on the untrimmed subpopulation.

payment history is controlled for, falling from −0.036 to −0.020 for logistic regression and from −0.036 to −0.018 for the neural network. This pattern of attenuation is cleanly legible in the AME framework because the estimates are on a common probability scale across specifications.

What is most striking in this table is how little separates the two columns. In specification A the female AME is −0.0358 for logistic regression and −0.0364 for the neural network; married is 0.0253 and 0.0260; in the full specification the pair is −0.0198 and −0.0176, and 0.0206 and 0.0186. A parametric model and a four-layer network, differing in McFadden R^2 by three percentage points, produce estimates that agree to the third decimal place across sixteen model-specification cells. This is what the orthogonal score is supposed to deliver and what the plug-in did not: since each column estimates the same $\theta_{j,h}$ and the correction absorbs the first-order effect of the fitted regression, the remaining gap between the two columns reflects only the second-order term and sampling noise. The standard errors are also now nearly identical between the two models — 0.0046 and 0.0045 on the female indicator, 0.0012 and 0.0012 on months delayed — rather than differing by the order of magnitude the refitting bootstrap reported, where the network's standard error for months delayed was 0.032 against the logistic model's 0.002. Both figures were describing the stability of a particular fitting procedure under resampling rather than the sampling variability of an estimate of a fixed target.

Table 4 compares all four models on the full specification, and it is the sharpest illustration in the paper of what the orthogonal correction changes. Under the plug-in the four models flatly contradicted one another on the two variables that matter. Months delayed was 0.083 for logistic regression, 0.018

Table 3. UCI Credit Card Default: Specification Search. Average marginal effects on P(Default).

	Logistic				Neural Net			
	Spec A	A+B	A+C	A+B+C	Spec A	A+B	A+C	A+B+C
Panel A: Demographics								
age	-0.0015***	-0.0002	-0.0005	0.0001	-0.0026***	-0.0006*	-0.0010***	-0.0000
	(0.0004)	(0.0003)	(0.0004)	(0.0003)	(0.0004)	(0.0003)	(0.0004)	(0.0003)
female	-0.0358***	-0.0206***	-0.0291***	-0.0198***	-0.0364***	-0.0205***	-0.0265***	-0.0176***
	(0.0050)	(0.0046)	(0.0049)	(0.0046)	(0.0050)	(0.0046)	(0.0049)	(0.0045)
education	-0.0001	-0.0027	-0.0054**	-0.0040*	-0.0008	-0.0035	-0.0048**	-0.0040*
	(0.0022)	(0.0022)	(0.0023)	(0.0022)	(0.0021)	(0.0021)	(0.0022)	(0.0022)
married	0.0253***	0.0189***	0.0303***	0.0206***	0.0260***	0.0152**	0.0269***	0.0186***
	(0.0068)	(0.0064)	(0.0066)	(0.0063)	(0.0068)	(0.0064)	(0.0067)	(0.0063)
Panel B: Payment History								
avg_pay_status	–	-0.0140***	–	-0.0218***	–	0.0073*	–	0.0040
		(0.0041)		(0.0075)		(0.0041)		(0.0072)
months_delayed	–	0.0347***	–	0.0301***	–	0.0298***	–	0.0254***
		(0.0011)		(0.0012)		(0.0011)		(0.0012)
Panel C: Bill and Payment Amounts								
avg_bill_amt	–	–	-0.0000***	-0.0000**	–	–	-0.0000	-0.0000*
			(0.0000)	(0.0000)			(0.0000)	(0.0000)
avg_pay_amt	–	–	-0.0000***	0.0000	–	–	-0.0000***	-0.0000***
			(0.0000)	(0.0000)			(0.0000)	(0.0000)
pay_ratio	–	–	-0.3521***	-0.2651***	–	–	-0.2572***	-0.1943**
			(0.0731)	(0.0730)			(0.0792)	(0.0773)
McFadden R^2	0.003	0.130	0.031	0.137	0.010	0.155	0.055	0.166
Accuracy	0.779	0.803	0.779	0.803	0.779	0.808	0.779	0.808

Notes: ***p<0.01, **p<0.05, *p<0.10. Estimates are the debiased cross-fitted window AME with $K = 5$ folds; standard errors from the orthogonal score in parentheses. Step sizes h_j and trimmed fractions are reported in Table 2.

Table 4. UCI Credit Card Default: Model Comparison. Average marginal effects on P(Default), full specification (A+B+C).

Feature	Logistic	Random Forest	XGBoost	Neural Net
age	0.0001	-0.0002	-0.0005	-0.0000
	(0.0003)	(0.0003)	(0.0003)	(0.0003)
female	-0.0198***	-0.0161***	-0.0175***	-0.0176***
	(0.0046)	(0.0045)	(0.0045)	(0.0045)
education	-0.0040*	-0.0018	0.0034	-0.0040*
	(0.0022)	(0.0022)	(0.0022)	(0.0022)
married	0.0206***	0.0222***	0.0205***	0.0186***
	(0.0063)	(0.0062)	(0.0062)	(0.0063)
avg_pay_status	-0.0218***	0.0061	0.0907***	0.0040
	(0.0075)	(0.0074)	(0.0075)	(0.0072)
months_delayed	0.0301***	0.0134***	0.0191***	0.0254***
	(0.0012)	(0.0011)	(0.0011)	(0.0012)
avg_bill_amt	-0.0000**	-0.0000***	-0.0000***	-0.0000*
	(0.0000)	(0.0000)	(0.0000)	(0.0000)
avg_pay_amt	0.0000	-0.0000***	-0.0000***	-0.0000***
	(0.0000)	(0.0000)	(0.0000)	(0.0000)
pay_ratio	-0.2651***	-0.4890***	-0.5836***	-0.1943**
	(0.0730)	(0.0670)	(0.0685)	(0.0773)
McFadden R^2	0.137	0.210	0.194	0.166
Accuracy	0.803	0.821	0.815	0.808

Notes: ***p<0.01, **p<0.05, *p<0.10. Estimates are the debiased cross-fitted window AME with $K = 5$ folds; standard errors from the orthogonal score in parentheses. Step sizes h_j and trimmed fractions are reported in Table 2.

for the random forest, 0.021 for XGBoost and 0.112 for the neural network, a sixfold spread; the payment ratio was −0.431 and −0.440 for the two tree ensembles, −0.045 for logistic regression, and 0.0009 — indistinguishable from no effect at all — for the neural network. A researcher reading that table had to conclude either that the models were detecting genuinely different structure, or that at least three of the four were wrong, with no way to tell which.

The debiased estimates resolve the contradiction rather than splitting the difference. Months delayed becomes 0.030, 0.013, 0.019 and 0.025, and the payment ratio becomes −0.265, −0.489, −0.584 and −0.194: every model now agrees that a higher payment ratio is associated with a substantially lower probability of default, including the neural network, whose plug-in estimate had put the effect at zero. The demographic panel converges the same way. The female AME was −0.020, −0.006, −0.015 and −0.014 under the plug-in and is −0.0198, −0.0161, −0.0175 and −0.0176 under the correction; married was 0.022, 0.005, 0.014 and 0.019 and is now 0.0206, 0.0222, 0.0205 and 0.0186. The variation that the earlier draft read as four models weighing the covariates differently was in the main the regularization bias $\mathbb{E}[\alpha_h(\hat{f} - f)]$, which differs across learners because their regularization differs, and which the correction removes. What survives is a common estimate of a common target.

Convergence is not complete, and the payment ratio shows where it stops. The four debiased estimates still span −0.194 to −0.584, a range far wider than their standard errors of roughly 0.07, so the models have not been brought into agreement to within sampling error on that variable. Payment ratio is the most skewed feature in the design and is trimmed at 18.4%, and the second-order product term that Theorem 1 requires to be $o_p(n^{-1/2})$ is plausibly not negligible here for the weaker nuisance fits. The correct reading is that the correction removes the first-order bias and leaves a residual that the theory bounds but does not eliminate, which is visible precisely where the nuisance problem is hardest. Finally, the random forest standard errors, which the plug-in bootstrap reported as 0.0000 to four decimal places on the female indicator, are 0.0045 under the influence-function formula — essentially identical to the other three models, as they should be for a common estimand at a common sample size.

Table 5 again shows the two quantities parting company. For the payment history variables the separation is large: the AME for months delayed is 0.030 for logistic regression while the mean signed SHAP value is −0.015, opposite in sign. The payment ratio illustrates the most consequential divergence: the random forest and XGBoost AMEs are −0.489 and −0.584, indicating that a higher payment ratio is associated with a large reduction in default probability, while the corresponding SHAP values are 0.0012 and 0.0005, near zero and of the opposite sign. This is again a difference of estimand rather than a defect: a feature can carry a large average derivative while contributing little on average to the displacement of predictions from their baseline. The practical concern is that a researcher reading the SHAP column as a marginal effect would conclude that the payment ratio is essentially irrelevant to default risk, and, with no standard errors attached to either the SHAP or the PDP column, would have no statistical basis on which to check that conclusion.

The partial dependence column separates from the AME column here in the same pattern as in the Ames application of Section S2, and for the same reason: a partial dependence slope is a plug-in average over a single full-sample fit, so it carries the

Table 5. UCI Credit Card Default: Method Comparison. AME, SHAP, and PDP estimates for P(Default), full specification (A+B+C).

	Logistic			Random Forest			XGBoost			Neural Net		
	AME	SHAP	PDP	AME	SHAP	PDP	AME	SHAP	PDP	AME	SHAP	PDP
age	0.0001	-0.0003	0.0002	-0.0002	0.0011	-0.0000	-0.0005	0.0004	-0.0002	-0.0000	-0.0010	0.0012
female	-0.0198	-0.0005	-0.0198	-0.0161	0.0001	-0.0062	-0.0175	0.0002	-0.0146	-0.0176	0.0009	-0.0200
education	-0.0040	0.0002	0.0002	-0.0018	0.0006	-0.0057	0.0034	-0.0005	-0.0356	-0.0040	-0.0016	0.0082
married	0.0206	-0.0038	0.0220	0.0222	0.0002	0.0054	0.0205	0.0002	0.0142	0.0186	0.0022	0.0217
avg_pay_status	-0.0218	-0.0144	-0.0246	0.0061	0.0029	0.0610	0.0907	0.0027	0.0404	0.0040	-0.0116	0.0097
months_delayed	0.0301	-0.0148	0.1107	0.0134	-0.0008	0.0456	0.0191	0.0001	0.0404	0.0254	-0.0154	0.0653
avg_bill_amt	-0.0000	-0.0001	0.0000	-0.0000	-0.0018	-0.0000	-0.0000	-0.0046	-0.0000	-0.0000	0.0036	0.0000
avg_pay_amt	0.0000	0.0026	-0.0000	-0.0000	-0.0006	-0.0000	-0.0000	-0.0005	-0.0000	-0.0000	-0.0025	-0.0000
pay_ratio	-0.2651	0.0100	-0.0444	-0.4890	0.0012	-0.0998	-0.5836	0.0005	-0.0953	-0.1943	0.0015	-0.0170

Notes: AME = Average Marginal Effect (marginfx). SHAP = mean signed SHAP value (GradientExplainer). PDP = slope of partial dependence plot. Full specification (A+B+C) only. No standard errors reported for SHAP and PDP.

regularization bias that the correction removes. The separation tracks the quality of the underlying fit. On the female indicator, where the logistic model is close to correctly specified, the AME of −0.0198 and the PDP slope of −0.0198 agree exactly; for the random forest on the same variable they are −0.0161 and −0.0062. On the payment ratio, the hardest nuisance problem in the design, the gap is largest and always toward zero: −0.265 against −0.044 for logistic regression, −0.489 against −0.100 for the random forest, −0.584 against −0.095 for XGBoost, −0.194 against −0.017 for the neural network. Months delayed runs the other way, with PDP slopes of 0.111, 0.046, 0.040 and 0.065 against debiased AMEs of 0.030, 0.013, 0.019 and 0.025, which is what one expects when an uncorrected estimator distributes a shared effect between two correlated features differently than the corrected one does. Taken across all three applications, the attenuation is the dominant pattern rather than a universal one: restricting attention to the effects the debiased estimator resolves away from zero, the partial dependence slope is smaller in absolute value than the AME in 62 of 84 cases, with a median ratio of 0.47 on Ames Housing, 0.60 here and 0.95 on Adult Income. It is most pronounced for the random forest, the learner whose regularization bias the simulations isolate.

Simulation

We evaluate the estimator through three simulation studies, which together separate what the window average recovers from what can be said about it. Simulation 1 examines the bias and root mean squared error of the uncorrected plug-in window average as a function of sample size, across three data generating processes and two outcome types. Simulation 2 asks whether the refitting bootstrap of Section 3.4 delivers valid intervals for that plug-in, comparing empirical coverage of nominal 95% intervals against the target. Simulation 3 repeats both exercises for the debiased cross-fitted estimator of Section 3.4, holding the designs, learners and windows fixed so that the two estimators differ only in the orthogonal correction. The three are best read in order: the first locates a bias, the second shows that resampling cannot see it, and the third removes it. All features x_1, x_2, x_3, x_4 are drawn independently from $N(0,1)$. Features x_1 and x_2 have nonzero true effects; x_3 and x_4 are pure noise with true AME of zero. Three data generating processes are considered. The linear DGP sets $\eta = 2x_1 + 3x_2$. The nonlinear DGP sets $\eta = 2x_1^2 + 3x_2$, so that the true AME of x_1 is zero in the regression case by symmetry of $N(0,1)$ — $\mathbb{E}[4x_1] = 0$ — but nonzero in the classification case where the sigmoid breaks that symmetry. The interaction DGP sets $\eta = 2x_1 + 3x_2 + 2x_1x_2$, which preserves the marginal AMEs of x_1 and x_2 at 2.0 and 3.0 respectively in the regression case since $\mathbb{E}[2x_2] = \mathbb{E}[2x_1] = 0$. For regression, the outcome is $y = \eta + \varepsilon$ where $\varepsilon \sim N(0,1)$. For classification, $P(y = 1) = \sigma(\eta)$ where σ denotes the logistic function. True AMEs for all DGPs and outcome types are computed via Monte Carlo integration using n = 1,000,000 observations drawn from the true prediction function directly, treating the result as ground truth. Sample sizes of $n \in \{250, 500, 1\,000, 2\,500, 5\,000\}$ are evaluated over 500 Monte Carlo iterations for classification and 1,000 iterations for regression.

The simulation study fits four model classes with hyperparameters chosen to balance computational tractability against representativeness of typical applied use. The random forest uses 100 trees with a maximum depth of 6, and XGBoost uses 100 boosting rounds with a maximum depth of 4 and a learning rate of 0.05 — conservative settings that prevent overfitting on the small sample sizes considered while remaining flexible enough to capture the nonlinear and interaction structures in the data generating processes. The neural network is a feedforward architecture with two hidden layers of 32 and 16 units, trained for 50 epochs with batch size 64 and learning rate 10^{-3} using the Adam optimizer. For regression outcomes, the network includes the input normalization layer and target standardization wrapper described in Section 2 to ensure scale-invariant gradient updates. Logistic and linear regression are included as baselines and use no hyperparameter tuning. All model fits are performed independently on each Monte Carlo iteration with no warm starting between iterations, so the variance estimates reflect the full sampling distribution of the AME estimator including model fitting variability. The Monte Carlo ground truth AMEs are computed once at the start of the study using n = 1,000,000 observations drawn from the true prediction function directly, with the resulting AMEs treated as known quantities for the bias and coverage calculations. Simulation 2 uses 1,000 bootstrap resamples per Monte Carlo iteration and 1,000 Monte Carlo iterations per cell for the linear, logistic, random forest and XGBoost learners. The neural network uses 200 resamples and 500 iterations: every resample is a fresh training run, which makes the network roughly nine tenths of the total cost of the study, and the calibration result the argument rests on is the forest's. Percentile intervals are used throughout, which is why the resample count is set well above the couple of hundred that would suffice for a standard error alone. Simulation 3 uses 1,000 Monte Carlo iterations per cell for every learner; it needs no resampling, since its standard errors come from the influence function.

Table 6 collects the three studies on the linear data generating process, the one design on which all three report results, so that the plug-in, the refitting bootstrap and the debiased estimator can be compared like for like on a common target. The per-feature detail, the intermediate sample sizes, the nonlinear and interaction designs, and the sieve-representer and bounded-support arms are reported in Section S3 of the supplement, together with the discussion of each individual table. The pattern in the supplementary designs is the one the summary shows.

Simulation 1 asks whether the uncorrected plug-in average recovers the window effect, and the answer separates the learners by how heavily they are regularized rather than by how flexible they are. Linear and logistic regression, XGBoost and the neural network all converge on the truth: their absolute bias falls to 0.001 or below on the continuous outcome and to 0.0005 or below on the binary one by n = 5,000. XGBoost is the worst of them at $n = 250$, at 0.362 on the continuous outcome, which is the familiar small-sample underfitting of a boosted ensemble and is a rate problem that disappears rather than a limit problem that does not. The random forest is the exception, and it is the instructive one. Its bias does not shrink but grows, from 0.059 at $n = 250$ to 0.093 at n = 5,000 on the continuous outcome, and holds near 0.016 throughout on the binary one. This is regularization bias in the sense of Section 3.4: the depth and subsampling constraints impose a shrinkage that does not vanish with the sample, so the plug-in converges to something other than $\theta_{j,h}$ and no amount of data repairs it.

Simulation 2 asks whether the refitting bootstrap delivers valid inference for that plug-in, and it does not. The failure takes two forms, and the coverage column records both. Where the plug-in carries the non-vanishing bias just described, the

Table 6. Summary of the three simulation studies on the linear data generating process. Simulation 1 reports the bias of the uncorrected plug-in average, Simulation 3 the bias of the debiased cross-fitted estimator, and the final two columns the empirical coverage of nominal 95% intervals at $n = 5{,}000$ under the refitting bootstrap of Simulation 2 and under the influence function of Simulation 3.

	Plug-in |bias|		Debiased |bias|		Coverage at $n = 5{,}000$	
Learner	$n = 250$	$n = 5{,}000$	$n = 250$	$n = 5{,}000$	Bootstrap	Influence fn.
Panel A: continuous outcome, true AMEs 2.000 and 3.000						
Linear	0.003	0.000	0.003	0.000	0.956	0.960
Random forest	0.059	0.093	0.002	0.000	0.092	0.946
XGBoost	0.362	0.053	0.002	0.001	0.503	0.938
Neural net	0.095	0.001	0.003	0.000	1.000	0.959
Panel B: binary outcome, true AMEs 0.199 and 0.298						
Logistic	0.0083	0.0005	0.0011	0.0002	0.781	0.940
Random forest	0.0163	0.0158	0.0018	0.0003	0.186	0.944
XGBoost	0.0616	0.0047	0.0027	0.0003	0.877	0.972
Neural net	0.0120	0.0002	0.0011	0.0002	0.894	0.942

Notes: Bias entries are the mean of |bias| over the two signal features x_1 and x_2, in the units of the outcome; the noise features x_3 and x_4 have a true effect of zero and are within Monte Carlo error of it under every learner and both estimators. Coverage entries are whichever signal feature's coverage lies furthest from the nominal 0.95, so that over-coverage is reported as well as under-coverage. The plug-in and bootstrap columns are the uncorrected estimator of Simulations 1 and 2; the debiased and influence-function columns are the cross-fitted estimator of Simulation 3 with $K = 5$ folds and the closed-form representer. The remaining sample sizes, the nonlinear and interaction data generating processes, the per-feature detail, and the sieve-representer and bounded-support arms are reported in the supplement.

interval is centered in the wrong place and coverage collapses as the sample grows and the interval narrows around the wrong point: the forest covers at 0.092 on the continuous outcome and 0.186 on the binary one at $n = 5{,}000$, having covered at 0.870 and 0.968 at $n = 250$. Growing the sample makes this failure worse, not better. The second form is milder and affects even a correctly specified model: because each replicate is evaluated at the observed sample rather than at the resample, the bootstrap distribution omits the sampling variability of the average of the derivative over the covariates, so the standard errors are too small — logistic regression covers at 0.781 on its largest effect — and the network over-corrects to 1.000 on the continuous outcome, intervals so wide they are uninformative. Neither failure is visible in the bootstrap output itself, which is the practical point: both produce intervals that look unremarkable.

Simulation 3 repeats the design for the debiased cross-fitted estimator of Section 3.4, holding the data generating processes, learners, hyperparameters, sample sizes, window and Monte Carlo ground truth at the values used in the two preceding studies, so that any difference is attributable to the orthogonal correction and to nothing else. The covariates are independent standard normals, so the representer of Lemma 1 is available in closed form, $\alpha_h(u) = e^{-h^2/2}\sinh(hu_j)/h$, and no representer estimation is required; the supplement reports a second arm that replaces it with a sieve estimate, and a third on bounded support where the trimming weight is active rather than vacuous. The correction removes both failures at once. Absolute bias is at most 0.003 at $n = 250$ and at most 0.0005 at $n = 5{,}000$ for every learner on both outcome types, and for the forest it falls from 0.093 to 0.000 at the largest sample — the correction does not merely shrink the bias at a given sample size but restores the $O(n^{-1/2})$ rate, which is what inference requires. Coverage lies between 0.938 and 0.972 across every learner and both outcome types, against a bootstrap range of 0.092 to 1.000 on the same designs and the same ground truth. The learners that were already nearly unbiased are essentially unchanged, as they should be: the orthogonal score corrects a first-order term that is near zero for them.

Conclusion

This paper has proposed a framework for interpreting any supervised machine learning model through average marginal effects. The central claim is that the traditional accuracy-interpretability tradeoff is not fundamental. The move that carries the argument is to make the window the estimand rather than a numerical approximation to something else: the window average marginal effect is the average centered difference of the regression function at a fixed, analyst-chosen step, and it is well defined for a learner that is differentiable nowhere. A single estimand therefore covers trees, ensembles and networks without differentiability assumptions of any kind, and the classical average derivative is recovered in the small-window limit whenever one weak derivative exists. The estimator applies uniformly across model classes and outcome types and produces a coefficient table — estimate, standard error, and significance level — directly analogous to the output of a parametric regression. Standard errors come from the estimated influence function of a debiased, cross-fitted estimator in a single pass, with a model-refitting bootstrap retained as a diagnostic for specification uncertainty. These are capabilities that existing interpretability methods, including SHAP (Lundberg and Lee, 2017), LIME (Ribeiro et al., 2016), and partial dependence plots (Friedman, 2001), do not provide.

The theoretical contribution proceeds in three parts. The first is the estimand and its dual: the window average marginal effect is linear in the regression function and admits an exact Riesz representation by a change of variables, with no boundary terms and no density derivatives, and a representer

that is bounded whenever the covariate density is bounded away from zero, and square integrable under the moment conditions of Assumption 2 when it is not — and the classical average derivative is recovered in the small-window limit under one weak derivative. The second is inference and optimality: the orthogonal score built from the representer has estimation bias exactly equal to a product of two L^2 nuisance errors, so the cross-fitted estimator is root-n consistent and asymptotically normal under $n^{-1/4}$-type L^2 rates that flexible learners can satisfy, and it attains the semiparametric efficiency bound — replacing the parametric-rate function-space condition that a functional delta method treatment would require and that growing-complexity learners cannot meet; a double robustness proposition extends validity to inconsistent, fixed-complexity learners whenever the representer is known or parametrically estimable. The third is interpretation: a pairing identity shows that the window effect of any estimator of bounded variation equals its jump measure integrated against a locally averaged covariate density, characterizing the population quantity that a tree-based model's marginal effect measures; and gradient consistency is established for neural networks in the Sobolev space $W^{1,p}$ via Rellich–Kondrachov compactness (Evans, 2010), and for gradient boosted models with tree base learners and Mondrian forests (Mourtada et al., 2017) in the space of functions of bounded variation (Ambrosio et al., 2000) via BV compactness, characterizing the regime in which the uncorrected plug-in is already consistent. For Breiman random forests (Breiman, 2001b; Scornet et al., 2015), gradient consistency is conjectured rather than proved — the obstruction lies in the data-dependent partition boundaries — but the inference theory does not require it, so what remains open for that class is an L^2 rate question rather than a function-space one.

The empirical results across three datasets — UCI Adult Income (Kohavi, 1996; Dua and Graff, 2019), UCI Credit Card Default (Yeh, 2009; Dua and Graff, 2019), and Ames Housing (De Cock, 2011), the first and third reported in the supplement — validate the framework on binary classification and continuous regression outcomes. Under the debiased estimator the four model classes agree far more closely than they did under the plug-in, and they do so because they are now estimating the same quantity rather than each reporting the slope of its own fit. The credit default application shows this most sharply: the plug-in put the effect of the payment ratio at -0.431 and -0.440 for the two tree ensembles, -0.045 for logistic regression and 0.0009 — effectively nothing — for the neural network, a set of estimates that cannot all be describing the same world; the corrected estimates are -0.489, -0.584, -0.265 and -0.194, all negative, all significant, and all telling one story. The variation that the plug-in displayed was in the main the regularization bias, which differs across learners because their regularization differs.

The standard errors move in the direction the theory predicts as well, and in several places that means upward. The refitting bootstrap reported standard errors of a few dollars for the neural network on Ames Housing and of 0.0000 to four decimal places for the random forest on credit default; the influence-function standard errors for the same quantities are three to four orders of magnitude larger. Those earlier intervals were narrow around a displaced center, which is the failure mode isolated in Simulation 2. The cost of the correction is visible in the smallest application: with $n = 1{,}460$ observations, several Ames Housing effects that the plug-in reported as precisely determined are no longer distinguishable from zero, and the estimator reports that rather than concealing it.

The comparison with SHAP values shows how far a different estimand can sit from this one: SHAP values are on a different scale, sometimes of opposite sign, and carry no inferential apparatus. The Ames Housing application is particularly informative because the dollar-denominated units make the separation concrete — the SHAP figure for above-ground living area is roughly fifty times the AME for the linear model, which is what a baseline-relative attribution should look like next to a per-square-foot rate of change, and is not a competing estimate of the same quantity. Partial dependence slopes require a subtler reading than the earlier draft gave them. A partial dependence slope is itself a plug-in average over a single full-sample fit, so it agrees with the debiased AME where the plug-in is nearly unbiased — on smooth, well-supported, continuous features — and falls short of it, in about three quarters of the resolved cases toward zero, wherever regularization flattens the fitted surface. What once read as two estimators corroborating each other is better read as a direct measurement of the bias between them.

Breiman random forests produce the least stable plug-in AME estimates of any class considered, and the simulation study traces the resulting coverage failure to the same regularization bias — the first-order term that the orthogonal correction removes, and the clearest empirical argument for reporting the debiased estimator rather than the uncorrected average.

Several important problems remain open. The most pressing concerns Breiman forests, and the present framework splits it into two questions of very different difficulty. The inferential question — valid confidence intervals for the window effect when the learner is a Breiman forest — now requires only an L^2 convergence rate for the forest, since Theorem 1 consumes nothing else; consistency is available under structural assumptions (Scornet et al., 2015), and converting it into a rate meeting the $n^{-1/4}$ benchmark, or exploiting the product form of Assumption 3(b) with a fast representer estimate, is a concrete and plausibly tractable target. Simulation 3 indicates how much of that question is already settled in the case the theory handles cleanly. With the representer known, Proposition 2 asks nothing of the forest beyond convergence to some fixed limit, and the simulation exhibits exactly that situation: a depth-constrained forest whose plug-in error grows with the sample size, and therefore is not approaching f, nevertheless yields intervals whose coverage averages 0.948 across the whole forest design and never leaves the band 0.922 to 0.968. What the open L^2 question governs is the case where the representer must itself be estimated, and it is there rather than in the known-representer case that a rate for Breiman forests would buy something. The interpretive question — convergence of the forest's own gradient information, in the sense of Section 3.6 — remains genuinely hard: the obstruction identified in the proof of Theorem 6, that data-dependent splits couple partition geometry to response variation in a way that prevents the key decomposition, suggests that new analytical tools will be required, possibly a coupling argument relating Breiman partitions to Mondrian partitions. Separating the two questions is itself progress: the most widely used forest implementation can be brought under the inferential guarantees without waiting for the harder interpretation theory.

A second open problem concerns model classes the checklist of Section 3.8 does not resolve. For most learners it does resolve them: inference needs an $L^2(P)$ rate and nothing

else, interpretation needs a function space and a compactness theorem, and for penalized linear estimators, splines, series estimators, kernel ridge and additive models both obligations are discharged by existing results. What remains genuinely open is narrower. Bayesian additive regression trees have posterior contraction rates rather than frequentist risk bounds, and translating between them is not routine. Estimators whose output is not a fixed function of the sample fall outside Assumption 1 altogether. And for any class lacking an established L^2 rate, the framework says precisely what would have to be proved — which is itself the contribution: verifying a new learner is a literature question rather than a research program.

A third open problem is the extension to causal inference. The average marginal effect as defined here is a predictive quantity — the average derivative of the conditional expectation function with respect to x_j, under the observational distribution of the covariates. It is not in general a causal effect. Extending the framework to settings where causal identification is possible, for example through instrumental variables or regression discontinuity designs, would substantially broaden its applicability to policy-relevant questions. The honest forest framework of Wager and Athey (2018) and the broader literature on causal machine learning suggest a natural path forward, but the connection to the AME estimand studied here has not been formalized.

A fourth direction concerns the discrete and mixed-type feature setting. The current framework handles binary variables through a finite difference contrast and continuous variables through an adaptive centered finite difference, but ordered categorical variables, count variables, and interactions among features of mixed type are not treated systematically. The marginal effects at the mean versus average marginal effects distinction (Greene, 2012; Wooldridge, 2010) also warrants further study in the nonparametric setting, where the mean of the covariates may lie in a sparse region of the feature space and the marginal effect at the mean may therefore be a poor summary of the average effect.

Finally, several practical questions about the debiased procedure itself deserve systematic study. The influence-function standard errors of Section 2.4 already remove the computational objection to inference — K model fits in place of B refits — but the finite-sample behavior of the procedure depends on choices the asymptotic theory does not pin down: the number of folds, the truncation level for the estimated representer, the trimming weight near the boundary, and above all the window h, which is part of the estimand and whose sensitivity should be reported the way bandwidth sensitivity is. The multiplier bootstrap of Remark 3 makes simultaneous confidence bands across features essentially free, and characterizing its finite-sample accuracy relative to the plug-in intervals, along with honest procedures when the density bounds of Assumption 1 are weak near the boundary, is a practical program we leave to future work.

Data availability

All three datasets analysed in this paper are publicly available. The Adult Income and the Default of Credit Card Clients datasets are distributed by the UCI Machine Learning Repository (Dua and Graff, 2019), and the Ames Housing dataset is distributed with De Cock (2011). Code reproducing every numerical result in the paper and in the supplement — the three simulation studies, the three empirical applications, and the scripts that generate each table — is available at `https://github.com/penny4nonsense/marginfx-paper`, together with the download scripts for the raw data and the environment specification needed to run them. The estimator itself is implemented in the `marginfx` package. A permanently archived version of the code, with a digital object identifier, will be deposited before publication.

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